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COMMENCES: JUNE 10TH, 2026

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COMMENCES: 29TH JUNE, 2026
MODE: OFFLINE | ONLINE

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- Post-test discussion for each test



COMMENCES: 15TH JUNE, 2026
MODE: OFFLINE | ONLINE

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MODE: OFFLINE | ONLINE

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CAMP 2026

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COMMENCES: 8TH JUNE, 2026
MODE: OFFLINE | ONLINE

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PROGRAMME

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- Essay Programme
- Sure Shot Mains Test Series (8 GS Tests + Mentorship)
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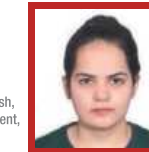
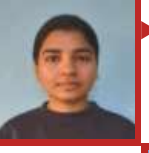
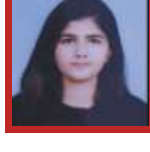
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MENTORSHIP
PROGRAMME 2027

- 4-layered mentorship including UPSC-selected mentors
- One-pager revision notes (Mains Smasher)
- Essay workshops, practice tests and feedback
- PYQ-based preparation and reverse engineering
- CSAT strengthening sessions
- Prelims & Mains Test Series



COMMENCES: 15TH JUNE, 2026
MODE: OFFLINE | ONLINE
MEDIUM: HINDI | ENGLISH

Anuj Agnihotri
AIR 1
IGP

 Rajeshwari Suve M AIR 2 PowerUp Prelims Test, IGP, Mains Test Series	 Akansh Dhull AIR 3 General Studies	 Raghav Jhunjhunwala AIR 4 IGP	 Ishan Bhatnagar AIR 5 Sociology Opt. Crash, Sociology Enrichment, Prelims CAMP, IGP	 Zinnia Aurora AIR 6 GS Ethics, IGP, PowerUp 23 Combined Tests	 A R Rajah Mohaideen AIR 7 IGP
 Pakshal Secetry AIR 8 IGP, Mains CAMP	 Asha Jain AIR 9 IGP	 Ujjwal Priyank AIR 10 IGP	 Yashaswi Raj Vardhan AIR 11 IGP	 Akshit Bhardwaj AIR 12 General Studies, Prelims CAMP, IGP	 Ananya Sharma AIR 13 IGP
 Surabhi Yadav AIR 14 Ethics Answer Writing Programme, IGP	 Simrandeep Kaur AIR 15 IGP	 Monika Srivastava AIR 16 GS Ethics, Sure Shot Mains, Essay, SMART CA, IGP	 Sruthi R AIR 18 General Studies, Sociology Opt, IGP	 Nisar Dishant Amrutlal AIR 19 IGP	 Shubham Singh AIR 21 Ethics Answer Writing, Ethics Module

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**SHAKTI DUBEY**
2024
GS, Sure Shot Main, Power UP Prelims SMART CA

**ADITYA SRIVASTAVA**
2023
IGP

**ISHITA KISHORE**
2022
GS, IGP

**SHRUTI SHARMA**
2021
GS, IGP, SMART CA

**SHUBHAM KUMAR**
2020
IGP

**PRADEEP SINGH**
2019
IGP

**KANISHAK KATARIA**
2018
GS, IGP

**DURISHETTY ANUDEEP**
2017
GS, Essay

**NANDINI KR**
2016
IGP

**TINA DABI**
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- Nutrition & Dietetics
- Clinical Psychology
- Pharmacy
- Nursing

- 



Manavala Nagar residents take to cartoons to flag sewage pollution near Putlur check dam

The clean stretch of Cooum near the check dam in Tiruvallur district is heading towards degradation as in urban stretches owing to sewage release. Residents who have been fighting for restoration of the portion have launched awareness campaigns through cartoons titled 'Koovam Kudineer'

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A section of residents in Manavala Nagar near Chennai has taken to cartoons to draw attention to the growing sewage pollution in the upper reaches of the Cooum river, particularly near check dams.

The clean stretch of Cooum river near Putlur check dam in Tiruvallur district, located about 40 km from Chennai, is heading towards degradation as in urban stretches owing to

sewage release. Residents of Manavala Nagar, Tiruvallur, who have been fighting for restoration of the portion have now launched awareness campaigns through illustrations and cartoons.

D. Anandhakrishnan, resident of Manavala Nagar, said "I decided to attract people's attention towards the issue affecting groundwater through cartoons. These cartoons are titled 'Koovam Kudineer'. The illustrations are gaining traction in social media and messaging apps than



Residents noted that the Cooum river was a significant source of groundwater recharge in their locality.

long messages and videos." While some cartoons depict the network of check dams across the river and explain how water from Cooum river eventually reaches Chembarambakkam reservoir, one

of the Chennai's drinking water sources, others highlight concerns about declining groundwater levels.

Residents noted that the Cooum river was a significant source of groundwater recharge in their locality. However, urbanisation, and lack of proper sewage treatment and disposal facility, often led to discharge of raw sewage into the clean stretch of the river. Members of Manavala Nagar Residents' Welfare Association recently met Tiruvallur MLA T. Arunkumar to highlight the issue.

C. Aravind of Manavala Nagar said the association requested the MLA to take measures to operate the dysfunctional Periakupam sewage treatment plant and also increase sewage treatment capacity. Release of raw sewage not only affected the river but also Vengathur lake.

Residents stressed the need for urgent measures to curb sewage pollution from the rapidly urbanising areas along the Cooum river to protect the groundwater recharge zones, residents noted.

Wife, her friend held for murder of man whose torso was stuffed in suitcase

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Otteri police have arrested a woman and her friend for the murder of Ameer Ali, 40, whose torso was found in a suitcase at the Perambur railway station.

The victim's wife, Raheema, with the help of her friend Ashraf Ali, killed Ameer Ali.

Government Railway

police (GRP) had on Friday found a headless body of a person in a suitcase left unattended on platform no. 4 of the Perambur railway station.

The murder case was shifted to Otteri police station. The police said that Ameer Ali would often assault Raheema.

Unable to bear the assault, she planned to murder him with the help of her friend, the police said.

Experts at webinar stress early diagnosis of brain tumour

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Ahead of World Brain Tumour Day, observed on June 8, experts emphasised early diagnosis, and dispelled common misconceptions about the disease at a webinar organised by *The Hindu* in association with Kauvery Hospitals.

Speaking at the webinar, G. Jos Jasper, Head of Department, Brain and Spine Surgery, Kauvery Hospital, Trichy Cantonment, said certain warning signs must not be ignored.

He stressed the importance of early diagnosis and treatment for improving outcomes and quality of life in patients with brain tumours.

Ranganathan Jothi, chief brain and spine surgeon and director of Neurosciences, Kauvery Hospital, Vadapalani, said that MRI remained the standard for diagnosing brain tumours, while PET-CT scans helped accurately map the location of tumours and aided in surgical planning.

Krish Sridhar, group mentor for Neurosciences



and director, Institute of Brain and Spine, Kauvery Hospital, Radial Road, Chennai, said treatment aims to minimise the impact of tumours on healthy brain tissue through surgery, followed by radiation and chemotherapy when necessary.

Advances in technology have reduced the complication rate of brain surgery to below 3%, he said.

The panel said nearly 70% of the brain tumours were benign and clarified that stress, anxiety, and sleep deprivation had not been established as causes.

Genetic mutations and radiation exposure are considered greater risk factors, while evidence linking obesity and mobile phone radiation remains inconclusive, they said.

The webinar can be viewed at newsth.live/THKABY

Work begins to provide online tickets for darshan

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

In an effort to streamline darshan in large temples across the State, the Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments (HR & CE) Department has begun work to tweak its website for providing online tickets for devotees.

Minister for HR & CE, S. Ramesh, told *The Hindu* that a survey is under way to get the average number of devotees visiting a few temples on each day and during any particular time like *Pradosham*.

"We are trying to make things easier for all the devotees, including those from outstation, senior citizens, pregnant women, mothers with toddlers, and persons with disabilities. People who cannot wait in queues due to special circumstances, will be allowed direct darshan. When slots are fixed for darshan, there will be no need for brokers to provide services. It is also important for the safety of devotees. We are looking at the Tirupati Temple as a model. Tickets will also be available at the temple," Mr. Ramesh said.

He said that free darshan that is opted by a large number of devotees will not be affected in any manner due to this online ticket system.

"In fact, we are also factoring in local residents who visit these temples regularly. They will be able to visit without any disturbance," he said.

The trial for the online system is expected to be conducted in 15 days to a month. The implementation will be taken up in three phases. This will also help in accounting the beneficiaries of the *annadhaanam* scheme, he added.

108 ambulances record faster response time, city gets services in 6.14 minutes on average

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The 108 ambulance service has recorded a significant improvement in emergency response times across Tamil Nadu.

In Chennai, the average response time reduced from 7.45 minutes in 2023-2024 to 6.14 minutes in 2026-2027 (till April). Across the State, the average response time also improved, falling from 13.24 minutes to 11.22 minutes during the same period.

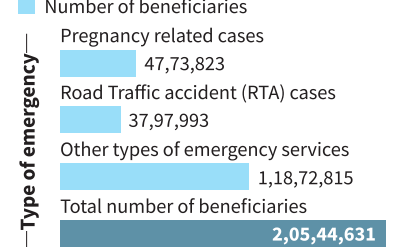
EMRI Green Health Services, which operates the ambulance network through the Tamil Nadu Health System Project and Government of Tamil Nadu, runs a total of 1,353 ambulances across the State. There are 66 first responder bikes, a press release issued by its State Head of Operations M. Selvakumar, said.

The network has achieved a reduction in response time through a

Rapid response

From September 2008 to May 2026, the average number of calls received in a day by '108' Ambulance Service from the Emergency Response Centre is 12,600

A look at the total number of beneficiaries of the '108' Ambulance Services

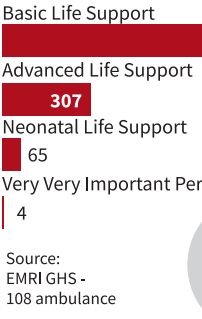


Comparision of response time in FY 23-24 and FY 26-27 *till April

Response Time	FY 23-24	FY 26-27*
Metro (Chennai)	00:07:45	00:06:14
Urban	00:11:47	00:10:07
Rural	00:14:15	00:12:18
Tribal	00:15:41	00:14:23
RTA Response Time	00:11:42	00:09:48
State	00:13:24	00:11:22



Types of ambulances



number of initiatives. This includes GPS fitment in all ambulances, based on the accident grid and cluster

analysis and scientific deployment of ambulances. The response time in attending to emergencies by

108 ambulance associates have been reduced drastically, the release said. At present, the average

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Last Date for Submission of Applications: **22.06.2026, 11:59 PM**
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Sd/-
Secretary and Registrar

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Adv.No: 07/2026
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NOTICE OF THE 104th ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING, E-VOTING AND BOOK CLOSURE INFORMATION
Notice is hereby given that the 104th Annual General Meeting (AGM) of the members of the **Tamilnad Mercantile Bank Limited**, will be held on **Tuesday, July 14, 2026**, at 11:00 A.M. IST through Video Conferencing ("VC") / Other Audio Visual means ("OAVM") without the physical presence of the members, at a common venue, in compliance with the applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 & rules made thereunder, read with MCA circular (vide General Circular No.03/2025 dated September 22, 2025) and in compliance with the applicable provisions of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, to transact the businesses as set forth in the Notice of the AGM.
In compliance with aforesaid MCA Circular and the applicable provisions of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, electronic copies of the Notice of the AGM, along with the Annual Report for the Financial Year 2025-26, will be sent to those shareholders whose e-mail address(es) are registered with the Registrar & Share Transfer Agent (RTA) / Depository Participant(s).
As per Regulation 36(1)(b) of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, a letter containing the web link, including the exact path and complete details of the Annual Report, will be sent to the shareholders who have not registered their email address(es) with the Registrar & Share Transfer Agent (RTA) or Depository Participant(s). Shareholders who have not yet registered their email address(es) are requested to update the same.
Further, the Notice and the Annual Report for the Financial Year 2025-26 will also be made available on the website of the Bank www.tmb.bank.in under 'Investor's Relations' section, on the website of Central Depository Services (India) Limited (CDSL) at www.evotingindia.com and on the website of Stock Exchanges i.e., BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com & National Stock Exchange of India Limited at www.nseindia.com in due course.
Pursuant to the provisions of Section 91 of the Companies Act, 2013 (the 'Act') and the rules made thereunder and in compliance with the Regulation 42 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 ("SEBI LODR"), the Register of Members and Share Transfer Books of the Bank will remain closed from Wednesday, July 08, 2026 to Tuesday, July 14, 2026 (both days inclusive).
Shareholders will be able to attend and participate in the AGM only through VC / OAVM. The details for joining the AGM through VC / OAVM will be provided in the Notice of the AGM to be sent to the Shareholders.
In accordance with the applicable circulars issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs, the Bank is providing to its Members facility to exercise their right to vote on resolutions proposed to be passed at the AGM, by electronic means ("e-Voting"). The Bank has engaged the services of Central Depository Services (India) Limited ("CDSL") as the agency to provide e-Voting facility.
The remote e-Voting schedule is as under:

Commencement of e-Voting	Saturday, July 11, 2026 at 9:00 A.M. IST
End of e-Voting	Monday, July 13, 2026 at 5:00 P.M. IST
Cut-Off date for determining the eligibility for voting	Tuesday, July 07, 2026

Additionally, the Bank is providing the facility of voting through e-Voting during the AGM for the members who have not exercised the remote e-Voting facility earlier. Detailed procedure for remote e-Voting / e-Voting during the AGM will be provided in the Notice.
In case of any queries, you may refer the Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs) for Shareholders and e-Voting user manual for Shareholders available at the download section of www.evotingindia.com or call on: 1800 21 09911 or send a request to Mr. Rakesh Dalvi at helpdesk.evoting@cdslindia.com
The Board of Directors in their meeting held on April 27, 2026, recommended a Final Dividend of ₹12.50/- per equity share of the face value ₹10/- each, for the Financial Year 2025-26, subject to the approval of the Shareholders at the ensuing AGM of the Bank. The Record Date for determining the eligibility for entitlement of dividend for the Financial Year 2025-26 is **Friday, June 12, 2026**.
Pursuant to Income Tax Act, 2025, dividend income is taxable in the hands of shareholders and the Bank is required to deduct tax at source (TDS) from the dividend paid to shareholders at the prescribed rates as mentioned in the Income Tax Act, 2025. The rate of TDS would vary depending on the residential status of the shareholder and documents registered with the Bank.
Shareholders who are not liable to pay Income Tax, can submit the Forms 12141 online in the website of our Registrar & Share Transfer Agent by accessing the following web link <https://web.in.mpmg.mufg.com/formsreg/submission-of-Form-12141.html>, not later than **June 12, 2026**.
Members may note that as per extant guidelines of SEBI, it is mandatory for shareholders holding securities in physical form in listed entities, to furnish PAN, Bank account details, Specimen Signature, Contact Details and Address. With effect from April 01, 2024, SEBI has mandated that all dividends shall be paid only after submission of all the above-mentioned particulars. Henceforth, the Bank's RTA i.e., MUG Intime India Private Limited, will attend to all service requests of the shareholders with respect to transmission, dividend, etc., only after updating the above details in their records.

**By Order of the Board of Directors
For Tamilnad Mercantile Bank Limited**
Sd/-
Swapnil Velgaonkar
Company Secretary
(Membership No: ACS 21877)

Date : 06.06.2026
Place : Thoothukudi

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INBRIEF



Cong. govt. compromising on
Telangana's water rights: MLA

Former Telangana Minister and BRS MLA T. Harish Rao accused the Congress government of compromising on water rights by linking the proposed Godavari-Nallamalasagar project with the Palamuru-Rangareddy Lift Irrigation Scheme. He said the State was entitled to 45 tmc ft water allocation in Krishna waters if Godavari was diverted to the Krishna basin by Andhra Pradesh. "Any attempt to link the two projects amounts to surrendering Telangana's legal rights," he said.

Hyderabad man shot dead
during pizza delivery in U.S.

A 28-year-old Hyderabad man was allegedly shot dead in Philadelphia, United States, while carrying out a pizza delivery on Friday. The victim, Anshul Kuncha, had moved to the U.S. almost four years ago for higher education. The family said he was employed at a multinational company and took up pizza deliveries during weekends to supplement his income. The family has sought the Centre's intervention to expedite the repatriation of Anshul's mortal remains.

Karnataka schools introduce
module for value education

With an aim to instil morality, good behaviour, and social responsibility in schoolchildren, the Karnataka government has introduced a value-education module from Classes 1 to 10 in all schools this academic year. "Instead of teaching value education as a separate subject, steps have been taken to integrate it with all subjects," an official from the State Educational Research and Training Department said. Over a lakh teachers have already been trained for the module.



Ticket to ride: D.K. Shivakumar interacts with passengers while travelling on a metro train in Bengaluru on Sunday. K. MURALIKUMAR

Karnataka CM takes
Metro rail to avoid
disruptions to traffic

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

In a bid to avoid causing inconvenience to citizens by accessing zero-traffic arrangements, Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar travelled by Namma Metro from Vidhana Soudha to Silk Institute on Sunday.

Mr. Shivakumar was visiting Kanakapura, his home turf, for the first time after becoming the Chief Minister to meet and extend his gratitude to the people of his constituency.

"The Chief Minister arrived at this decision after recognising that using zero-traffic all the way from his Sadashivanagar residence to Kanakapura Road would disrupt traffic movement for the public," a statement from his office said.

The Chief Minister interacted with metro commuters at the station and inside the train, exchanging pleasantries. After getting down at the last station on Kanakapura Main Road, Mr. Shivakumar proceeded to Kanakapura by road.

Last week, the facilitation of zero traffic for Governor Thaawarchand

Shivakumar was
visiting Kanakapura,
his home turf, for
the first time after
becoming CM

Gehlot's convoy at Wind Tunnel Junction, where underpass work is ongoing, sparked public outrage after a frustrated man staged a protest by sitting down at the junction. He claimed that his wife was pregnant and he was on the way to the hospital.

VIP movement

The incident triggered widespread outrage on social media, with many pointing to Bengaluru's crumbling infrastructure, which has already made commuting difficult.

They argued that VIP movement and the associated traffic restrictions were causing further inconvenience to the public.

Home Minister, Priyank Kharge, also discussed the issue during his first meeting with IPS officers on Friday. He said they were trying to work out alternate solutions, like synchronised signals to avoid blocking other traffic.

TDP names three candidates
for elections to Rajya Sabha

The ruling party says the candidate selections have been made with a focus on social engineering and to encourage young leadership; Jana Sena, NDA ally in Andhra Pradesh, fields one candidate

The Hindu Bureau
VIJAYAWADA

The Telugu Desam Party (TDP) has announced Chintakayala Vijay, Bhashyam Ramakrishna, and sitting Rajya Sabha member Sana Satish as the candidates for the forthcoming elections to the Upper House.

TDP national president and Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu presented the B-Forms to them at his camp office on Saturday.

Mr. Vijay is the son of Assembly Speaker Chintakayala Ayyanna Patrudu and the party's State general secretary.

For Mr. Satish, this is his re-nomination to the Rajya Sabha. He was elected to



TDP candidates for Rajya Sabha polls (from left) Chintakayala Vijay and Sana Satish, and Bhashyam Ramakrishna (right) with party president N. Chandrababu Naidu. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

the Upper House in 2024 and his term is set to expire on June 21.

Mr. Ramakrishna is the founder-chairman of Bhashyam educational institutions.

The TDP stated that the

selections were made with a focus on social engineering, dedication and loyalty to the party, and to encourage young leadership.

The leaders who could not be accommodated in the current round of politi-

cal appointments would be considered for other positions in the future, the party added.

Ally choice

The TDP's ally in the ruling NDA alliance in the State, Jana Sena Party, has named industrialist Lingamaneni Ramesh.

Mr. Vijay hails from north Andhra and the other three are from the central coastal region.

Some leaders from the Greater Rayalaseema region, which spans from Prakasam to Chittoor districts, have expressed displeasure over the selection of candidates. The leaders questioned the lack of representation from the 11 districts, which comprise nearly half of the State.

Salim Kumar cremated with state honours

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

Malayalam actor-filmmaker Salim Kumar, who started as a mimicry artiste and went on to win the National Award for Best Actor in an inspiring career, was cremated at North Paravur, his hometown in Ernakulam district in Kerala, on Sunday with state honours.

Thousands of people, including his colleagues from the film industry, political leaders and fans from across the State, gathered

to pay their last respects to the popular actor at North Paravur Municipal Town Hall.

The funeral of the 57-year-old actor, who died of a cardiac arrest, was conducted on the premises of his residence at Chittattukara.

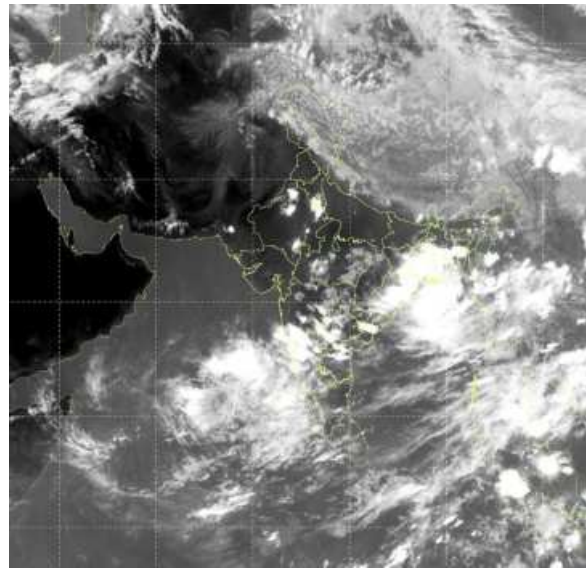
Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan paid last respects to the actor at the town hall and also attended the funeral. He remembered Salim Kumar as someone with whom he shared a "brotherly bond."



Kerala Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan pays his last respects to actor Salim Kumar in Ernakulam on Sunday. R.K. NITHIN

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 17.00 HRS)

Forecast for Monday: Heavy to very heavy rainfall with isolated extremely heavy rainfall very likely at isolated places over coastal Karnataka. Heavy to very heavy rainfall very likely at isolated places over Interior Karnataka, Kerala, Mahe, West Bengal and Sikkim.

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala		35.5	27.1	Kurnool		4.0	36.4
Ahmedabad		41.5	30.2	Lucknow		40.4	28.1
Aizawl		15.8	33.8	Madurai		38.0	26.5
Bengaluru		3.0	29.5	Mangaluru		38.0	23.5
Bhopal			21.6	Mumbai		35.8	30.0
Bhubaneswar		3.0	39.2	Mysuru		29.2	20.2
Chandigarh		25.6		New Delhi		40.0	25.8
Chennai		40.4	30.4	Patna		2.0	38.0
Coimbatore			32.2	Port Blair		8.0	29.6
Dehradun				Prayagraj			25.9
Gangtok		7.0	24.3	Puducherry			27.6
Goa		28.2		Pune		37.4	25.5
Guwahati			33.8	Raipur			41.9
Hubballi			28.0	Ranchi		1.0	34.6
Hyderabad		3.0	37.6	Shillong		0.8	28.3
Imphal			30.5	Shimla			27.4
Jaipur		0.3		Srinagar			28.2
Kochi		28.0	28.4	Thiruvananthapuram		6.0	31.4
Kolkata				Tiruchirappalli			38.7
Kohima		15.0	35.3	Vijayawada			35.0
Kozhikode		53.0	32.4	Visakhapatnam			

Pollutants in the air you are breathing							Yesterday	
CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM _{2.5}	PM ₁₀	CODE		
Ahmedabad		76	31	53		97		In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Dhanbad, Jharkhand recorded an overall air quality index (AQI) score of 291
Bengaluru		11	45	48		114		indicating an unhealthy level of pollution. In contrast, Madikeri, Karnataka recorded a healthy AQI score of 16
Chennai		5	5	16	29	84		
Delhi		25	59	39	85	276		
Hyderabad		15	19	34	62	81		
Kolkata		16	37	17	63	84		
Lucknow		12	25	49	104	110		
Mumbai		2	5	40	30	99		
Pune			21	94	28	78		
Visakhapatnam		26	57	14		133		

Air Quality Code: ■ Poor ■ Moderate ■ Good (Readings indicate average AQI)
SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.
NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.
CO: Carbon Monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.
PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

Kerala government issues orders
reinstating suspended IAS officers

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The United Democratic Front (UDF) government in Kerala has issued orders revoking the suspensions of IAS officers B. Ashok and N. Prasanth.

Both officers had been placed under suspension during the Left Democratic

Front (LDF) government's term on charges of criticising the government.

In separate orders dated June 6 issued by Chief Secretary A. Jayathilak, the suspensions stand revoked with "immediate effect".

Mr. Prasanth, a 2007-batch officer, was placed under suspension in 2024, for levelling serious allegations

against Mr. Jayathilak, then Additional Chief Secretary, and former Chief Secretary Sarada Muraleedharan.

Mr. Ashok, a 1998-batch officer, was Vice-Chancellor, Kerala Agricultural University, and Principal Secretary, Sainik Welfare, when he was suspended in April for criticising government policies on social media.

THE HINDU
Air Surcharge as applicable:
New Delhi - Rs. 15/-
Port Blair - Rs. 20/-

CHITTARANJAN LOCOMOTIVE WORKS

OPEN E-TENDER NOTICES

The following e-Tenders can be accessed under the link www.ireps.gov.in. Offers for such e-Tender can be submitted only electronically by accessing the link www.ireps.gov.in → login → E-Tender Stores/Supply. Vendors may also contact the following officials to obtain clarification regarding particular tender or IREPS related information if any. Dy. CMM/HQ/CLW/Chittaranjan, 9163340711 or AMM/HQ, 9163340713 for notice SL No. [A] and Dy. CMM/HQ/CLW/Chittaranjan, 9163340711 or AMM/HQ-II, 9163340724 for notice SL No. [B]. Office Address: Office of the PCMM/CLW/Chittaranjan. [A] Notice No. COS/CRJ/PUB/e-Tender/19/0162, Date: 04/06/2026. Sl. No.: [1]. Tender No.: 73263713B. Brief Description of Item: High Tensile Transition C.B. Coupler Without Draft Gage as per RDSO Drg. No. - SK-DL-3430, ALT-8 or latest except item nos. 18 to 20,24 to 47 along with part Drg. Nos. SK-62724 alt-23 or latest, SKDL-2496 alt-6 or latest, SK-69508 alt-4 or latest, SKDL-2494 alt-17 or latest and SKD L-2495 alt-12 or latest. [Warranty Period: 30 Months after the date of delivery]. Quantity: 387.00 Nos. Earnest Money Deposit (Rupees): ₹72640.00. Tender Closing Date & Time (IST): 24/06/2026 at 11:00 AM. [B] Notice No. COS/CRJ/PUB/e-Tender/19/0162, Date: 04/06/2026. Sl. No.: [1]. Tender No.: 70261255B. Brief Description of Item: Modified Cow Catcher Assy for WAG-9HC Loco To Specification No. CLW/ MS/ 3/107 ALT-8, DRG NO.1209-02.140-032 ALT-11 [Warranty Period: 30 Months after the date of delivery]. Quantity: 336.00 set. Earnest Money Deposit (Rupees): ₹390460.00. Tender Closing Date & Time (IST): 26/06/2026 at 11:00 AM. PRS/365 PCMM/CLW/Chittaranjan visit us on: www.facebook.com/clwrailways

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Cleaner, Sharper and Bolder

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Or write to us at
customercare@thehindu.co.in

THE HINDU **thehindubusinessline.**
FRONTLINE SPORTSTAR THE HINDU YOUNG WORLD THE HINDU

BANGALORE ELECTRICITY SUPPLY COMPANY LIMITED
(Wholly owned by Government of Karnataka undertaking)
(CIN-U04010KA2002SGC030438)

NOTIFICATION INVITING TENDER (NIT)
(Through KPP Portal)

No: BESCOM/CGM(Proj)/DGM-1/AGM-1/BC-14/
26-27/CYS-80

BESCOM Invites a tender for the work of "Conversion of existing 11KV Overhead line into UG Cable to reduce power outages, to improve quality & reliable power supply to Industrial consumers in Harohalli sub division, Kanakapura Division, Ramanagara circle, BESCOM" on Total Turnkey basis under Percentage Quoting basis.

Tender Enquiry No: BESCOM/2026-27/EL/WORK_INDENT1099. **Availability of Bid documents:** 08.06.2026 onwards. **Last date for submission of bid Queries:** 19.06.2026 before 17:00 Hrs. **Pre-Bid meeting:** 20.06.2026 @ 11:00 Hrs. **Venue of Pre-Bid meeting:** O/o Chief General Manager (Ele), 4th Floor, Project Section, B Block, Corporate office, BESCOM, K. R Circle, Bangalore- 560 001. **Last date & Time for bid submission:** 08.07.2026 before 15:00 Hrs. **Opening of Technical Bids:** 09.07.2026 @ 15:30 Hrs.

The bid documents can be downloaded and necessary assistance can be obtained through the e-procurement portal from the website <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>
E-procurement Help Desk: Phone No: **+91-8046010000** **+91-8068948777**, E-mail: support@prochelpdesk.com
Aspiring bidders needs to be registered on e-procurement portal. Bidders can take the assistance from the e-procurement during office working hours.

Sd/-
Chief General Manager (Ele.),
Projects, BESCOM
For Electricity related complaints call: 1912
Download "BESCOM Mittra" Mobile APP E mail: cgmproject.bescom@gmail.com

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

He has fought the good fight, finished his course and gone to be with the Lord.

PRABU DAWSON
22.06.1950 - 07.06.2026
Funeral Service
On Tuesday, 09.06.2026 at 3.00 PM
St. Paul's Church, Choolai, Chennai.
Burial: Kilpauk Cemetery at 4.00 PM

Deeply mourned by
Family & Friends
Ph: 9884048511 / 9384600805

Safe with God,
Forever at Peace

Sandeep Isaac Joseph
Retd. Exec Director Hindustan Petroleum
July 7, 1955 - June 7, 2026
Son of (late) Capt. J. Joseph & (late) Molly Joseph
Husband of Tanya;
Father of Rohan
Brother of Arun & Anjali

OBITUARY

18-02-1943 - 07-06-2026
with profound grief and sorrow
we inform the sad demise
of our beloved
Dr.E.Gurusamy,
M.B.B.S., M.D (DCH)
S/o. Easwaramoorthy
who left for his heavenly abode on
07-06-2026 Sunday. His last rituals
will be held 09-06-2026 Tuesday
10.30am at his residence
Cremation at Velachery burial ground
with grief
Family & Friends
33/5B, 3rd Main Road,
Dhaneeswaram, Velachery, Ch-42

BIRTH CENTENARY

BIRTH CENTENARY
DOB: 8th June 1926
Retd. Supdt. GRH, Chennai - 600 014
Former HOD & Professor of
Orthopaedics KMCH, Chennai &
Founder Head of Accident Block GRH,
Chennai - 600 014
Dearest Dad, you only dealt in
superlatives - A great Son,
A great Husband, A great Teacher,
A great Brother, A great Friend,
A great Grand Father and
the Greatest Dad
- The Basheer's

DEATH
ANNIVERSARIES

SIXTH ANNIVERSARY
A.V.RAJESWARAN
Chief Engineer PWD (Retd)
DOD: 08.06.2020
Wife: R.Ratnakantha
Son: Dr.Venkateswaran
M.D.D.M., Former Director
Medical GE, MMC Chennai.
Relatives & Friends

SIXTEENTH ANNIVERSARY

**NAMBUNGAL
R.NARAYANAN**
DOD - 08.06.2010
We Miss you..
Family & Friends
Mob: 98410 50221

DEATH
ANNIVERSARIES

3RD DEATH ANNIVERSARY

We miss you
every moment
in our life.
Your presence
continues to
surround us.
In our hearts, you
are always there.

C.S.LAKSHMANASWAMY
Exec. Engr. (Retd) TWAD Board
Fondly remembered by
L. Soundary (Wife) Family & Friends

TENTH ANNIVERSARY

S.SHANMUGADIVEL
B.A.,B.L.,D.SS.
Retd. Asst. Commissioner
of Labour, Chennai.
Fondly remembered by the FAMILY

In Loving Memory of

Sri V. Krishna Kumar
04.02.1946 - 08.06.2025
"To live in the hearts of those we leave
behind is not to die."
Always remembering you with love
Wife: Dr Nandini K. Kumar
Daughters: Rema and Jyothi
Sons-in-law: Puneet and Gokul
Grandchildren: Yashasvini & Kanishk

SEVENTH ANNIVERSARY

In ever loving memory of
V.S.SURAB B.Sc., MBA, MCA
Deputy General Manager,
Manapuram Finance Ltd. Kerala
10.06.1974 - 08.06.2019
Remembering every moment
in silent grief by
Prabitha (Wife)
Shyamak & Shrenik (Sons)
V.S.Subramanian, M.A.B.L. Advocate,
High Court, Chennai (Father)
Late. Lalitha (Mother)
V.S.Sishir (Brother & Family)
V.S.Sulab (Brother & Family)
AA 47 (7), 2nd Street, Anna Nagar
Chennai-40. Mob: 94449 18150



Testing times

GDP data reveal some strengths, but they will come under strain

The GDP growth data released on Friday simultaneously portray recent economic strength and reveal some reasons for worry. The provisional estimates of GDP growth for 2025-26 have been pegged at 7.7%, which is marginally higher than the 7.6% predicted by the government in February. This suggests that March, the first full month since the West Asia crisis erupted, did not see enough of an impact to affect the full year's growth. That resilience will be dented in the months ahead. The data also showed that several key sectors of the economy, such as manufacturing and several services sectors, grew by double digits over and above a relatively high base. These are all good signs for an economy heading into severe supply-related headwinds due to the war in Iran. Notably, both Private Final Consumption Expenditure and Gross Fixed Capital Formation – metrics of household consumption and government and private sector investment activity, respectively – grew faster in 2025-26 than they did in the previous year. The consumption growth is especially welcome given that it had been at a tepid 5.8% for the previous two years. It remains to be seen how much of the investment growth was driven by the private sector. Even if this growth was driven by government spending, it has positive knock-on effects on the rest of the economy.

The weakness in the agriculture sector, however, is something to worry about. The sector's growth slowed to 3% in 2025-26 from 4.2% in 2024-25, despite the 2025 monsoon having concluded at 108% of its long period average (LPA). This is dire news, given that the India Meteorological Department has predicted that this year's monsoon will only be 90% of the LPA. That is not counting the fertilizer supply constraints that will really be felt in the months ahead. The data also show the rising dominance of services in the economy, with their share rising to 54.3% of total gross value added (GVA) in 2025-26, up from 51.9% in 2022-23. The agriculture sector, which continues to employ the largest share of the population by far, saw its share in GVA fall to below 20% from 22.1% in 2022-23. The manufacturing sector's share has remained largely unchanged, another cause for concern. This suggests that India is not growing its value-added manufacturing sector fast enough. The Reserve Bank of India (RBI), government, and independent economists are in agreement that 2026-27 will see growth slowing significantly. The RBI predicted growth will dip to 6.6%, and the Chief Economic Adviser said that he saw no need to second-guess this estimate. Last year's tariff-related disruptions were a test of India's export resilience. This year's energy supply disruptions will test the entire economy as well as the government's policy agility.

Missed call

India must brace itself for a deficient southwest monsoon

The southwest monsoon reached Kerala on June 4, three days past its normal date and four days behind the India Meteorological Department's own forecast. This is the first time since 2015 that the agency has misjudged the onset beyond its margin of error. A late arrival, in itself, is no calamity. The date on which the rains touch the Kerala coast has little statistical bearing on how much falls over the four months that follow. Many times in the past, the monsoon has begun early and failed, and also begun late and recovered. It is what the monsoon has in store over the next four months that is unsettling. The India Meteorological Department has pegged seasonal rainfall at 90% of the long-period average, with a 60% probability of an outright deficient year – its most pessimistic pre-season call in a decade. Only the northeast is expected to see normal rain; the northwest, central India, the peninsula and the monsoon core zone that waters most of the country's rain-fed farmland are all forecast to fall short. As monsoon watchers have often cautioned, it is the distribution – the sudden long dry spells, sown crops that then face the danger of being unwatered – that matters. Every monsoon is consequential for India. This one is exceptionally so, because it arrives atop an input crisis. The West Asia conflict and the disruption at the Strait of Hormuz earlier this year throttled energy supply and fertilizer production.

History offers little comfort. Around 60% of El Niño years since 1951 have brought deficient or below-normal rains; 2002, 2009 were the severest droughts of the century with significant shortfalls in 2014 and 2015. With El Niño now near-certain through the heart of the season, the government must not count on a late, redeeming swing of the Indian Ocean Dipole. That means activating the Agriculture Ministry, Jal Shakti and Consumer Affairs Ministries on a war footing along with the disaster management authorities, with advisories steering farmers toward short-duration pulses, oilseeds and millets over thirsty paddy. Disciplined groundwater and reservoir management are necessary and crop insurance and relief provisioning must be readied. India will also have to brave more days of severe heat, which a parched landscape will only sharpen. The government as recently as last week claimed to deliver a record *kharif* production. While hoping for the best, it must prepare for the worst. A weak monsoon would fall on a farm economy whose nutrients and fuel are both already scarce and dear.

India is on the cusp of a demographic upheaval. Fertility rates across the country have been falling for decades and are now on or below replacement levels. We will soon have to shift from the challenges of finding jobs for the youth bulge to preparing to care for an ageing population.

You would not think so looking at the Terms of Reference (ToRs) of the High-Level Committee on Demographic Change that the government constituted at the end of May. The ToRs are peppered with the need to address “illegal immigration” and border management. Home Minister Amit Shah said on the social media site X while announcing the formation of the committee that “Illegal infiltration and other reasons leading to Unnatural Demographic Change is a very big challenge for the present and future of any nation.” It is no wonder that the committee does not have a single demographer to guide its work. Its chairperson is a retired Supreme Court of India judge; it has a retired IAS officer and a retired IPS officer, the Census Commissioner and an economist.

The infiltration narrative expands

Using strong words about “infiltrators”, the Prime Minister had announced the need for such a committee from the ramparts of Red Fort on August 15, 2025. Indeed, this was the culmination of years of building a mythology that undocumented (Muslim) migrants from Bangladesh are swamping the districts on the border, spreading across the country and influencing electoral outcomes. It was way back in 2018 that Amit Shah, then Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) President, said that Bangladeshi migrants were termites. The mythology about hordes of immigrants has seeped into the citizen's consciousness and has served well the electoral purposes of the BJP.

It has worked very well in Assam during a couple of election cycles, and it was stunningly effective in West Bengal during the recent elections where the need to deal with “infiltration” was a central feature of the BJP campaign. It is perhaps time now to make it a nation-wide campaign aided by the recommendations of the Demographic Change Committee.

Given how the issue has been highlighted and framed, we can have a fair idea of what the recommendations of this committee will be. It is still important to understand why this has little to do with demographic challenges and is all about moving to the next stage of the “Othering” of India's minorities, especially Muslims.

To begin with, what is the evidence of large-scale undocumented immigration from Bangladesh? It is revealing that the only kind of official evidence we have so far of “demographic change” (i.e., immigration from Bangladesh



C. Rammanohar Reddy

Writer based in Hyderabad

affecting population size and composition) are observations by the Home Minister of large increases in the population of a few of the border districts. Highlighting such increases without reference to domestic migration or differential fertility behaviour among communities is not proof of undocumented immigration. It is instructive that studies that had been done by official agencies showing evidence of demographic change in the border districts were removed without explanation, according to a report in this daily (“Government proposal in 2024 for a panel on ‘demographic challenges’ never took off”, August 16, 2025). We can only presume that they were deleted because they did not stand scrutiny.

This is not about undocumented migration

For decades there has indeed been cross-border migration between India and Bangladesh across what is an integrated riverine ecology. But given the economic transformation that has taken place in Bangladesh in recent decades, it would be hard to argue for economic distress driving large-scale migration from Bangladesh to India. India's neighbour is no “basket case” as it was derisively described decades ago.

According to World Bank data, Bangladesh's per capita income (in nominal dollar terms) grew faster than India during 2005-23 (10.4% versus 7.70% compound annual growth rate); it now has roughly the same income as India's. In purchasing power parity terms, India's growth is slightly higher. Both countries presently have roughly the same per capita income however measured, and both now have the same levels of human development, according to the UNDP's Human Development Index. But the change in Bangladesh has been much faster. Why then would there be migration to India of a scale that there should be talk of being swamped? There would certainly remain pockets of distress forcing the poor to consider migrating to India and the more skilled to West Asia. But we cannot find economic evidence to suggest waves of Bangladeshis being pushed by distress to migrate to India, ending up affecting jobs and electoral outcomes here.

Of course, all this is not about undocumented migration. All this is really a code for the place of Muslims in India and an acceleration of the social, economic and political discrimination of this community of Indian citizens that has taken place over the past 12 years. And here the government has given a more dangerous diktat to the committee. Item (iv) reads “to analyse structural population changes at the level of religious or social communities, particularly where they deviate from broader trends”. This in particular is about the fertility behaviour of Muslims and “where they deviate from broader trends”.

For a century now, the Hindutva campaign has

The Demographic Change Committee may become a platform to institutionalise the targeting of minorities

From borderland to India's strategic resource frontier

Within days of one another, official platforms of the Ministry of Mines cast several northeastern States in a similar frame – as repositories of strategic minerals and untapped potential. Manipur was described as a “quiet mineral frontier”, Arunachal Pradesh as a “resource-rich frontier”, while Meghalaya and Mizoram were portrayed through comparable narratives that emphasised the hidden wealth beneath their hills. Governments routinely publicise natural resources and development opportunities, and such descriptions would ordinarily attract little attention.

Taken together, however, they point to a broader shift in the language through which the northeast is increasingly being framed in the national conversation and strategic picture.

The critical mineral push

The timing is significant because critical minerals have moved from geological discussions into strategic ones. Lithium, cobalt, graphite, nickel and rare earth elements increasingly shape industrial competition, technological manufacturing and energy transitions. Batteries, semiconductors, renewable technologies and defence systems depend upon them, and countries have begun repositioning themselves around access to these resources. India itself continues to depend on imports for several critical minerals and has consequently expanded exploration efforts. According to a Ministry of Mines reply in Parliament, the Geological Survey of India undertook 43 critical mineral exploration projects across northeastern States during the 2022-23, 2023-24 and 2024-25 field seasons, covering minerals such as graphite, vanadium, lithium, rare earth elements, nickel and cobalt. Exploration activity has expanded across Arunachal Pradesh, Meghalaya, Assam, Nagaland and Manipur. In Manipur, projects involving nickel, cobalt and chromium exploration have recently been initiated.

Geological surveys have pointed toward mineral potential across the region for years.



Sangmuan Hangsing

Researcher and alumnus of the Kautilya School of Public Policy

Critical mineral ambitions must account for the people, land and history of northeast India

What appears to be changing is the language through which that significance is increasingly being understood. The northeast has long held strategic significance that extends beyond geology, but the framework through which that significance is understood now appears to be widening.

Shift in language

For decades, the northeast has figured in national strategy largely through the language of borders and security. Discussions have centred on insurgencies, territorial management, connectivity initiatives and geopolitics considerations involving neighbouring countries, while infrastructure and development were often justified as instruments of strategic access and territorial security.

The language of resources is increasingly entering a strategic space once dominated by concerns over borders and security. Critical minerals are now discussed alongside trade corridors and geopolitical access, with territorial and resource security converging. Places once viewed mainly as sensitive border regions are increasingly seen as strategic assets.

The repeated use of the word frontier is revealing, because frontiers rarely function as neutral descriptions. They do not merely describe geography; they often reflect how States imagine it. Historically, frontiers have been viewed as spaces awaiting integration, development or extraction because they appear as landscapes of future possibility.

The difficulty is that frontiers are rarely empty spaces waiting to be discovered. The hills and valleys of the northeast already contain dense social and political worlds structured around customary land systems, local institutions and long-standing relationships with territory. Questions of land often extend beyond economics, as they are also tied to authority, identity and memory. Resource extraction thus enters landscapes that already possess institutions and histories of their own.

whipped up fears of Muslims overtaking Hindus in population.

This is now firmly impregnated in the minds of Hindus of all ages, classes, castes and regions. It is to be found in everyday social conversations, on social media of course, and it is expressed in less than thinly veiled terms during electoral campaigns.

When facts are ignored

It is tiresome to repeat the facts, but one has to, even when confronted by a wall of disinformation and prejudice. Yes, the share of Muslims in India's population has risen from 10% in 1951 to 14% in 2011, at the time of the last Census. Yes, in the past, the Muslim community on a whole has shown a higher fertility than the Hindus and other religious denominations. This has been on account of its poorer economic status, lower education of women and perhaps even religious beliefs. However, fertility among Muslim women has begun falling rapidly, with the result that the gap between Muslims and Hindus has narrowed and will soon disappear. On the desired number of children that women want to have, there is now almost no difference between Hindus and Muslims. So much for Muslims now having more children than Hindus. And to repeat what is well-known, the best example of why religion is not the determinant of fertility behaviour: Muslim women in Tamil Nadu, Kerala and Jammu and Kashmir exhibit lower fertility than the Hindu women of Bihar and Uttar Pradesh. Poverty and education matter more. This is the deviation that needs to be addressed, not fertility behaviour according to religion.

To speak then about Muslim fertility “deviating from broad trends”, as one of the ToRs of the committee indicates, is to ignore the facts on the ground and fall back on familiar tropes about the behaviour of this minority, giving official validation of age-old misinformation.

We cannot escape from the realisation that this committee is being asked to recommend steps to target minorities under the cover of checking undocumented migration. After all, we have already become an inhumane society where, according to reliable reports, government agencies have flown Rohingya refugees from Delhi to the Andamans and then pushed them into the sea with life jackets. So when the Demographic Change Committee is asked “to recommend a streamlined and permanent operational mechanism for the legal, fair, and time-bound identification, detention, and deportation of illegal immigrants already residing in the country”, there is a chilling similarity between the language of this “permanent operational mechanism” and the “Final Solution” practised in 1940s Europe.

We should not say we have not been forewarned.

These questions become particularly significant in regions where political uncertainties continue to shape everyday life. In Manipur, years of violence and displacement have intensified debates over land and territorial arrangements. Similar concerns about ownership, ecological vulnerability and local participation have surfaced across the northeast at different times. Projects involving land often acquire meanings that extend beyond development, as communities interpret them through the lens of trust, representation and political inclusion.

Resources and inclusion

India's search for critical resources is understandable within a global environment increasingly shaped by supply-chain uncertainty and strategic competition. The northeast itself also requires infrastructure, employment and economic opportunities that have remained uneven for decades. Questions surrounding resource development rarely fit neatly into positions of support or opposition.

How quickly these transitions unfold and who shapes them may matter as much as the resources themselves. For a very long time, national priorities and local realities in the northeast often moved at different speeds. Connectivity projects sometimes arrived without corresponding economic ecosystems, while strategic considerations frequently overshadowed questions surrounding participation and representation. Resource development risks reproducing similar tensions if extraction begins moving faster than institutions capable of managing its social consequences.

What is being debated extends beyond the minerals beneath the hills. The northeast has spent years being viewed first as a border to be secured and then as a corridor to be connected. If it now begins entering national imagination as a landscape of strategic resources, the question is whether this new frontier will finally include the people who already inhabit it, or merely assign another purpose to the land beneath their feet.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

The Hindu Huddle 2026

The 2026 edition of The Hindu Huddle, in Bengaluru, was an intellectually enriching experience that provided a remarkable platform for delegates to engage with an eclectic range of subjects – spanning the complexities of domestic and geopolitics

to the nuanced worlds of cinema, art, and music. The event was well-organised, ensuring a seamless and hassle-free experience for all in attendance. It is rare to find such a thoughtful curation of topics under one roof, and the depth of insight provided by the speakers was

commendable. One hopes that such vibrant dialogue continues to flourish in our city. **Ram Kumar Viswanathan,** Bengaluru

The sessions were well curated and offered an engaging blend of perspectives and

discussions. The sessions featuring the actors and the mentalist were particularly refreshing. I especially enjoyed the discussion with the diplomats from the EU and Australia. **L. Gopinath,** Bengaluru

It is distressing that Jammu

and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah unabashedly bemoans the abrogation of Article 370 while, in the same breath, urging the Centre to accord statehood to the newly carved-out Union Territory. He must reconcile himself to the changed realities and accept that the welfare of

Jammu and Kashmir can be better served now than under the erstwhile dispensation with Art.370.

Ravi Mathur, Noida, Uttar Pradesh

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address and the full name or the name with initials.

How ICMR is rewiring the health ecosystem

As the nation advances toward the vision of Viksit Bharat 2047, the question is not only about how to treat disease, but how one builds a health system that is anticipatory, equitable, and innovation-driven. At the heart of this transformation lies a reimagined approach to health, one that connects data to decisions and decisions to impact. Building on the hard-earned lessons of the COVID-19 pandemic, the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR), India's apex body for biomedical research, has undertaken a series of forward-looking reforms. These reforms range from reimagining its institutional architecture to strengthening the way research is funded and translated into impact. This shift reflects a deliberate move towards integrated, institute-led research aligned with national priorities, where science is designed not just to generate knowledge, but to solve pressing public health challenges.

A strategic reorientation
A cornerstone of this transformation is the restructuring of the ICMR's institutional architecture. Recent reforms have expanded the mandates of several institutes, repositioning them as interdisciplinary hubs rather than narrowly defined entities. The evolution of institutes toward domains such as digital health and data science, child health, and women's health reflect the changing contours of India's disease burden and technological capabilities. Another important step is the creation of a network of regional National Institutes of Health Research across the country, from Dibrugarh in the Northeast to Jodhpur in the west. These institutes will conduct operational research with State and district health systems to ensure that relevant research is conducted and the output is used on the ground. These changes signal a strategic reorientation toward future-ready science,



Rajiv Bahl
Secretary to Govt. of India, Department of Health Research, Ministry of Health & Family Welfare and Director-General, Indian Council of Medical Research

The roadmap to 2047 will be shaped by advances in digital health, bio-manufacturing, and sustainable development, with a strong emphasis on capacity building and global collaboration

where AI, genomics, and real-time data systems are integral to public health decision-making. Equally important is the shift from compartmentalised functioning to a connected national research ecosystem. Institutes are now envisioned as resource centres that contribute to a shared national mission, ensuring that evidence generated in one setting informs action across the country. This systems-level thinking is critical in an era where health challenges, be it antimicrobial resistance, pandemics, or non-communicable diseases, are complex and interconnected. Similarly, the research funding ecosystem is also going through a redesign. This integrated continuum marks a decisive shift from funding projects to enabling solutions. It is further reinforced by the National Health Research Programme (NHRP), which has identified 13 priority areas ranging from antimicrobial resistance and tuberculosis to mental health, nutrition, and emergency care. Technology, too, is playing a transformative role. The integration of AI into diagnostics, surveillance, and program implementation is helping bridge longstanding gaps between urban and rural healthcare. AI-enabled tools for tuberculosis and diabetic retinopathy screening are already supporting frontline health workers, while innovations such as AI-driven nutritional monitoring are improving program delivery at scale. The integration of AI into diagnostics, surveillance, and program implementation is helping bridge longstanding gaps between urban and rural healthcare. AI-enabled tools for tuberculosis and diabetic retinopathy screening are already supporting frontline health workers, while innovations such as AI-driven nutritional monitoring are improving program delivery at scale. The integration of AI into diagnostics, surveillance, and program implementation is helping bridge longstanding gaps between urban and rural healthcare. AI-enabled tools for tuberculosis and diabetic retinopathy screening are already supporting frontline health workers, while innovations such as AI-driven nutritional monitoring are improving program delivery at scale. The integration of AI into diagnostics, surveillance, and program implementation is helping bridge longstanding gaps between urban and rural healthcare. AI-enabled tools for tuberculosis and diabetic retinopathy screening are already supporting frontline health workers, while innovations such as AI-driven nutritional monitoring are improving program delivery at scale.

traditional knowledge systems through innovative, evidence-based models is gaining global recognition. Schemes such as First in the World Challenge complemented with platforms such as MedTechMitra and the Medical Innovations-Patent Mitra initiative are accelerating the journey from research to commercialisation, ensuring that publicly funded science translates into affordable, accessible technologies for the people. **Towards universal access**
The true measure of these reforms, however, lies in their impact on public health. Initiatives such as the India Hypertension Control Initiative have demonstrated how evidence-based strategies can transform chronic disease management at scale. Mission-mode programmes in emergency care, including mobile stroke units and rapid cardiac response systems, are redefining outcomes in life-threatening conditions. Expanded diagnostic networks and indigenous technologies are strengthening early detection and treatment across diseases ranging from cancer to infectious outbreaks. These efforts are closely aligned with the National Health Policy 2017, which emphasises preventive and promotive healthcare, universal access, and quality of care. As we look to the future, the vision is clear. The ICMR will continue to serve as a catalyst, bringing together researchers, clinicians, policymakers, and the industry to build a resilient health ecosystem. The roadmap to 2047 will be shaped by advances in digital health, bio-manufacturing, and sustainable development, with a strong emphasis on capacity building and global collaboration. The transformation underway within the ICMR is an invitation to all stakeholders to participate in this journey and to ensure that science serves society in the most meaningful way.

A united front for local body elections

All three parties of the ruling coalition are likely to eye the lion's share of seats

STATE OF PLAY

Hareesh. P

The elections to Urban Local Bodies (ULBs) in Andhra, likely to be held towards the end of 2026 or in the first half of next year, are set to pose an acid test for the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) partners, as they will have to navigate differences that may arise during the process of seat-sharing. While petitions are pending before the courts questioning the ongoing ward delimitation process, the bigger challenge before the NDA, and more particularly Chief Minister and Telugu Desam Party (TDP) national president N. Chandrababu Naidu, is the need to quell dissidence and ensure that the NDA emerges with flying colours in the elections. There are over 120 urban local bodies spread across the 175 Assembly constituencies in the State, and winning them gives political parties an edge ahead of the Assembly elections. This, however, is not always the case. The YSR Congress Party (YSRCP), which swept the ULB elections last time, could not capitalise on its success in the 2024 general elections due to a massive anti-incumbency wave that reduced the party's strength from 151 Assembly seats in 2019 to just 11 in 2024. **Proportional sharing**
As the number of wards are set to increase in corporations and municipalities, the number of leaders aspiring to contest in the ULB elections will also rise across all parties; there is bound to be competition among the ruling coalition leaders of the TDP, the Jana Sena Party (JSP) and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP).



The JSP, in particular, is likely to seek a larger share of corporator and councillor seats, as well as the posts of Mayors and Chairpersons. It had contested just 21 Assembly and two Lok Sabha seats in the 2024 elections, even though there was a strong demand from party leaders seeking a larger share, considering the prevailing political situation and the bargaining power JSP chief K. Pawan Kalyan wielded at the time. Mr. Kalyan, however, had strongly advocated the need for a united fight against the then incumbent YSRCP government. The JSP went on to record a 100% strike rate. Therefore, this time around, the party's leaders and cadre are hopeful that they will receive their rightful share in the local body elections in recognition of the party's contributions to the coalition's victory. The BJP, on the other hand, is keen to expand its grassroots presence in the State and hopes to use representation in local bodies to strengthen its organisational base. Similarly, buoyed by the victory it secured in the elections two years ago, TDP leaders too are hoping to secure the lion's share of seats, confident that local bodies generally favour the ruling party. This competition among leaders of the three parties for seats could lead to internal squabbles and even instances

of leaders working against the spirit of coalition politics, thereby hurting the alliance's prospects and inadvertently benefiting the YSRCP. This is where Mr. Naidu's political acumen will be put to the test, as the arduous task of containing dissidence and rallying the three parties behind a common strategy will rest largely on his shoulders. **Focus on local issues**
Moreover, Mr. Naidu could be wary of the possibility of the YSRCP winning a significant number of corporations, municipalities, or even seats in key local bodies such as the Greater Visakhapatnam Municipal Corporation and the Vijayawada Municipal Corporation. Such victories could energise the party's cadre and leadership, turning the results into a launch pad for the Assembly elections that are just three years away. The NDA will have to rely on local issues rather than solely banking on the government's much-publicised success of the 'Super Six' welfare schemes and its claims of development through investments. With local issues such as sanitation, sewerage systems, basic infrastructure and grassroots development expected to play a crucial role, the NDA will have to demonstrate what it has done to improve cities and towns over the past two years vis-à-vis the previous YSRCP regime. The early completion of elections and the formation of new executive and administrative bodies with elected public representatives at the helm, replacing the current Special Officer governance, would pave the way for a faster and more effective development of the ULBs.

hareesh.p@thehindu.co.in

India's pension scheme lags in terms of coverage, contribution

The Centre's contribution to India's flagship pension scheme has remained the same while the add-on contributions by State governments have increased

DATA POINT

Nitika Francis

The Indira Gandhi National Old Age Pension Scheme (IGNOAPS) – the Government of India's flagship cash assistance scheme for the elderly under its National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP) – is in dire need of a revamp as it remains frozen in time, since 2007, both in terms of the sum of ₹200 it offers per person per month and the roughly 2.2 crore beneficiaries it covers. The States and Union Territories (UTs) add their own contributions, ranging from ₹150 to ₹2,000, on top of the ₹200 offered by the Union government for the 60-plus age group or the ₹500 it offers for the 80-plus category. **Chart 1** shows how the Union government's contribution for this centrally-sponsored scheme has remained the same while the add-on contributions by State governments have increased between 2012 and 2023. States such as Telangana and Andhra Pradesh contribute the largest sums – of around ₹2,000. Many others do not bring as much to the table. Chhattisgarh offers ₹150, taking the total pension to ₹350, while West Bengal offers a total of ₹250. Goa and Manipur do not provide any additional amount. The call for increasing the quantum of assistance, number of beneficiaries and linking the assistance with inflation, as it is done for the payment of Dearness Allowance to government employees, has been made at least since 2013, when the task force constituted by the Ministry of Rural Development (MoRD) first made such recommendations. The latest official recommendations came from the Public Accounts Committee (PAC) of the Lok Sabha in 2025 and the report released in May 2026 based on an independent evaluation of the NSAP commissioned by MoRD. The evaluation report said that the

real value of the assistance fixed at ₹200 has “significantly eroded due to inflation, and that the amount should be increased to ₹353 to retain its original purchasing power”. An analysis by *The Hindu* based on the changes in the Consumer Food Price Index (CFPI) (base year 2012) at the all-India level showed that since 2013, the value of ₹200 has eroded to just around ₹99. This means that beneficiaries can buy only half the quantity of food items they could earlier buy with ₹200. Conversely, they should be receiving a minimum of around ₹400 to be able to afford even the small quantity of items they could buy with ₹200 in 2013 (**Chart 2**). Notably, the survey findings in the latest report highlighted that over 95% of the beneficiaries cited increase in prices as the main reason for their demand to increase the pension amount. More than 80% of them stated that the current pension amount does not cover their daily needs (**Chart 5**). The task force's report in 2013, the PAC's 2025 report and the recent MoRD report have all recommended an increase in coverage, stating that the Union government was relying on outdated BPL data to fix ceilings on the number of beneficiaries. The MoRD report estimated that the IGNOAPS beneficiaries should be nearly 17 crore at present and about 20 crore by 2030, which is 10-fold higher than the present coverage of 2.2 crore people. **Chart 3** shows how the number of beneficiaries have remained stagnant when compared with the projected growth of the elderly population. **Chart 4** shows the response of surveyed beneficiaries in nine States and Jammu and Kashmir for a study commissioned by Ministry of Rural Development (MoRD) on the adequacy of assistance under IGNOAPS. The report also surveyed 6,000 beneficiaries across 600 Gram Panchayats across 10 sample States. In nine out of these 10 States, less than 10% of respondents thought that the scheme was “fully adequate”, with a majority stating that it was only “somewhat adequate” or not adequate at all (**Chart 4**). *With inputs from Pon Vasanth B. A.*

Old and unsupported

The data for the charts were sourced from the Lok Sabha replies, the Ministry of Rural Development's report titled “Impact Assessment and Evaluation of NSAP”, and the Ministry of Statistics and Program Implementation

CHART 1: The monthly pension offered by all States, barring few Union Territories, under the centrally-sponsored Indira Gandhi National Old Age Pension Scheme (IGNOAPS) as of 2023

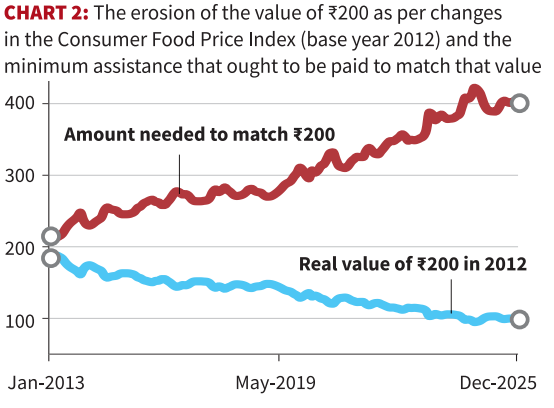
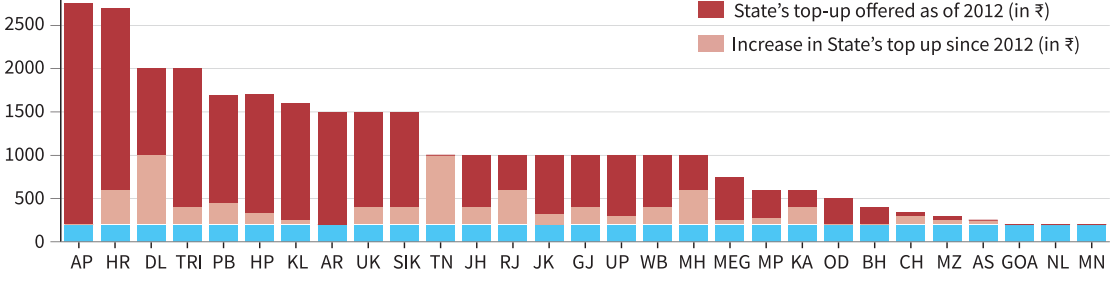


CHART 2: The erosion of the value of ₹200 as per changes in the Consumer Food Price Index (base year 2012) and the minimum assistance that ought to be paid to match that value

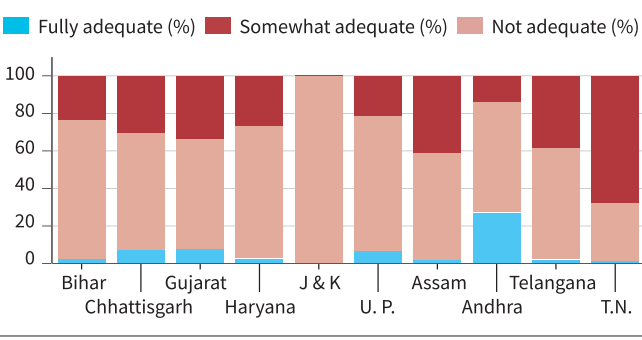


CHART 4: The response of surveyed beneficiaries in nine States and Jammu and Kashmir for a study commissioned by Ministry of Rural Development (MoRD) on the adequacy of assistance under IGNOAPS



CHART 3: Number of beneficiaries who have remained fairly constant over the years when compared to the projected growth in the elderly population (in crore)

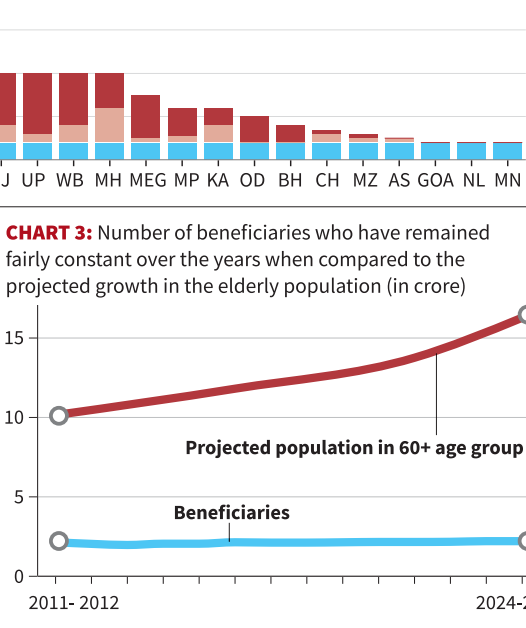
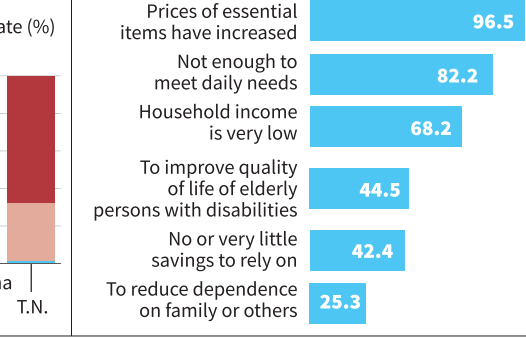


CHART 5: The reasons cited by respondents (%) of the MoRD study for the need to increase IGNOAPS assistance



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu

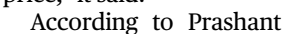
FIFTY YEARS AGO JUNE 8, 1976

Mango big money spinner for country

New Delhi, June 7: Mango, the king of fruits, is becoming a big money spinner for India. According to preliminary official estimates, exports of mango, mango slices, juice, jams, chutneys, and pickles will fetch the country nearly Rs. 10 crores this year. The exchange earnings through exports to Britain, Canada, West Asia, the Persian Gulf Sheikdom and other countries in 1975-76 were nearly Rs. nine crores. India produces annually about nine million tonnes of mango nearly 80 per cent of world's output. Of this Uttar Pradesh, the home of the succulent "dusehri" and "langra" contributes about 30 per cent (nearly 2.5 million tonnes). Lucknow, the capital of Uttar Pradesh, has been made famous by its sweet cream like "Dusehri" which attracted the Mughal kings to the abode of nawabs. This variety is at its best and sweetest in the latter half of June. This year the mango crop in U.P. has been damaged by powdery mildew which has also attacked some areas in Punjab, Haryana and Delhi. The mango harvest in U.P. this year will be two million tonnes but the loss in northern India will be made up by the bumper mango crop in South India. **A HUNDRED YEARS AGO** JUNE 8, 1926
A new anaesthetic
A demonstration of ethylene, an anaesthetic of American discovery, was given recently by one of the chief anaesthetists at the Manchester Royal Infirmary with such success as to assure its adoption in future in cases of a certain kind. The drug represents a further step in the search for the ideal anaesthetic, but is as yet only supplementary to other methods of anaesthesia. Its value lies principally in its applicability to cases not met by the ordinary forms of anaesthesia, principally those in which the patient is at one or the other extreme of life, or in diabetic, consumptive, or other cases in which the administration of the anaesthetics in common use is attended by a certain amount of poisoning of the system. The drug has the advantage of giving immunity from certain distressing after effects – "The Manchester Guardian".

Maharashtra Congress leader Vijay Wadettiwar alleged that the BJP was not concerned about issues affecting ordinary people like it had been when it was in the Opposition. "During the Congress government, they used to raise voice on the price rise of fuels and gas but now they are maintaining silence," he said.

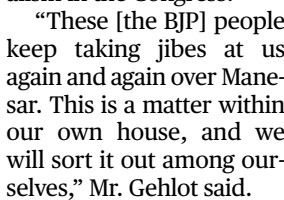
In a statement, the government said that state-owned oil marketing companies are now absorbing under-recoveries, that is, the difference between effective cost and selling price, on domestic LPG at about ₹700 per cylinder. At current rates, domestic



The conflict in West Asia has directly impacted about 54% of India's LPG demand.
(With inputs from
Devesh Kumar Pandey)

“Modiji and BJP leaders used to raise a hue and cry about inflation during the UPA era. Is it not true that the Modi government has increased domestic LPG prices by ₹530 over the last 12 years? Why aren’t BJP leaders taking to the streets with LPG cylinders in protest now?” he said.

Mr. Gehlot said the MLAs took the view that they had demonstrated loyalty to the party high



In another incident, a local Trinamool worker from Amta was found hiding under a pile of sarees during a police raid.



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ODISHA
NEW OPPORTUNITIES

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF GENERAL MANAGER (CIVIL), IDCO, IDCO TOWER, BHUBANESWAR
Bid Identification No.Civil/EST-14/2016-27 : TCN No.15533, dt.01.06.2026

NOTICE INVITING TENDER UNDER NATIONAL COMPETITIVE BIDDING THROUGH e-Procurement

1. Name of the Work : Construction of Block Level Stadium (without Indoor Hall), Purusottampur Block under Ganjam District

2. Value of the Work : Rs.9.62 Crore

3. Period of completion : 09 (Nine) Calendar Months

4. Availability of tender online for Bidding :

i. Start Date : 18:00 Hours of dt.10.06.2026

ii. End Date : 15:00 Hours of dt.24.06.2026

iii. Opening date : 16:00 Hours of dt.24.06.2026.

Tender details can be seen from the e-procurement portal: www.tendersorissa.gov.in. Corrigendum or Addendum if any will not be published in newspapers and can be seen in e-procurement portal as well as in IDCO website.

Sd/-

Chief General Manager (Civil) IDCO, Bhubaneswar

4001/124/2627

OJPR-4001/4075/1/26-27/0038

सौराष्ट्रईआर. राष्ट्रीय अंतरविषयी विज्ञान तथा प्रादेशिकी संस्थान
CSIR-NATIONAL INSTITUTE FOR INTERDISCIPLINARY SCIENCE AND TECHNOLOGY
इंडस्ट्रियल एस्टेट ड्राक घर, पाप्पनमकोड, तिरुवनन्थपुरम-695019
Industrial Estate PO, Pappanamcode, Thiruvananthapuram-695019.

WALK-IN-INTERVIEW

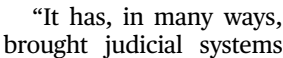
CSIR-NIIST invites interested and eligible candidates for
Walk-in-Interview to be held at NIIST-Thiruvananthapuram
for engagement of Project Staffs on temporary basis, to work
under various projects. For more details and application form
please refer www.niist.res.in.

Sd/-
प्रशासन निर्यंकक / Controller of Administration

Four workers died allegedly after inhaling toxic fumes while cleaning a tank at a jewellery manufacturing unit in Surat, Gujarat, on Sunday morning, the police said. While asphyxiation is likely the primary cause of their death, the exact cause will be confirmed by the post-mortem report, Deputy Commissioner of Police, Zone-1, Alok Kumar said. The incident occurred at the septic tank, which collects waste from the jewellery cleaning process, in Ashwini Kumar area, he said. "We are examining whose negligence led to the incident, as preliminary investigations show that safety protocols were not followed," he said. ^{PTI}

“Based on enquiries with the woman, [it was found that] she had consumed alcohol and energy drinks. No drug use was revealed.” The police are examining if it was a “rave party”. A similar incident had taken place in April at the NESCO centre in Goregaon, where two students died from a drug overdose.

“The Supreme Court of India has consciously approached technology as an aid to human reasoning rather than as a substitute for independent judicial thought. Considerable em-



He added that an AI system can process immense volumes of legal text with astonishing speed.

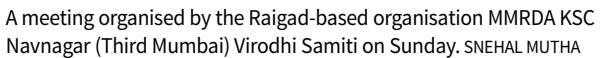
"The factsheets are the first stage of dissemination. The detailed national report will provide a much broader picture," sources said. The report will be released subsequently with a much wider range of indicators, detailed analyses and methodological documentation.

"The aim is to ensure

On the absence of anaemia estimates in the fact-sheets, they said that haemoglobin testing was not undertaken in NFHS-6 due to concerns surrounding the capillary blood sampling methodology used in previous rounds.

The deceased has been identified as Okale, a Nigerian national. He had sustained severe burns.

The Third Mumbai project, or Karnala-Sai-Chirner (KSC) New Town, includes 124 villages and spans a land area of 323 sq. km. The land is spread

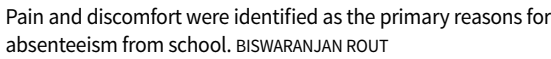


According to the Government Resolution issued in March, the landowners are to receive 22.5% developed land in return for the land sold or opt for compensation in

the form of floor space index and transferable development rights.

Activist Ulka Mahajan criticised the government, saying the project ignores laws, democracy and constitutional norms. Samitis representative and farmer Rupesh Patil advised his peers not to fall prey to inducements that could ruin their homes. "If we sell today, we won't be able to buy even half a *gunta* of land. Our land is no more farmland but has become a real estate hub."

Pain and discomfort were identified as the primary reasons for absenteeism, with lack of privacy, inadequate facilities, and social stigma also major factors. The assessment, conducted from April 28 to May 25 across several districts, revealed persistent gaps in menstrual hygiene management, sanitation infrastructure, awareness, and institutional support systems. The survey covered 177 respondents – 121 schools and 56 public institutions – from rural and



While 94% of the schools surveyed had separate toilets for girls, the lack of basic menstrual hygiene support systems, and non-availability of water and soap were cited as major hurdles. The study found that around 56% of schools either lacked menstrual waste disposal facilities

Over the past three years, public spaces in Bhubaneswar, have been audited by adolescents using the Public Spaces Assessment Framework developed by the World Resources Institute India, a

- 1 Local going after vehicle on highway from London to Leeds? It can lead to reduction in gas (11)
- 9 Wife leaves lawyer's coat (5)
- 10 Grand proposal to install gas lines to every house is fanciful thinking (4,5)
- 11 American consuming sodium first? Disgusting! (10)

- ## Down
- 1 Rodent is shy at first, perhaps unsettled, for starters (5)
 - 2 Are rather confused about metal not available in pure form in nature (4,5)
 - 3 Start to produce units manufactured to make feedstocks (6)
 - 4 Adds, "Badly snapped" (7)
 - 5 Indian and Yankee in a motor sport (4)
 - 6 Entice ox running around university for performance (9)
 - 7 Throws fine fish on top of salver (6)
 - 8 Meaning: One drink, after commencement of May (6)
 - 14 Cod dives strangely consuming current media storage device (5,4)
 - 16 A new advice: With Italian wine, for starters (9)
 - 17 In absence of war, brainwash distraught and exile (6)
 - 18 After school, parent gets choke (7)
 - 20 The French aristocrat is pardoned (3,3)
 - 21 Rose, you and I punt badly (4,2)
 - 24 Put in vase and badly ruin before noon (5)
 - 25 Against rebellious Anglican leaving clan (4)

4	3	5	2	7	6	9	1	8
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3	5	6	7	2	8	1	9	4
1	8	7	9	4	5	3	2	6

Immersed in Perumal and His qualities, the works of the Ayzhars are an outpouring of divine bliss. Poigai Azhwar, Peyazhwar and Boothattazhwar composed on Vakkuntam and Ulagalandha Perumal. Tirumazhisai Azhwar focused on Antaryami, Kulasekhara Azhwar sang on Rama, Tondaradipodiazhwar and Tiruppannazhwar had eyes only for Lord Ranganatha, Madhura Kavi sang paeans on his guru, Tirumangai Azhwar sang about the Divya Desams. Nammazhwar, Periazhwar and Andal sang about Krishna but while the latter were Krishna devotees (bhaktas), Nammazhwar epitomised Krishna bhakti. In Periyai Tiruvandhadhi, when he engages Perumal in a debate on who is greater, Nammazhwar says, 'I am greater than You. You hold the entire universe, but since I hold You (with my devotion) I am greater.' Krishna Himself is fond of the devotee who places complete faith in Him. In Chapter VII of the Bhagavad Gita, Krishna says, "The man of realisation I regard as my very Self, for with his mind (fixed) on Me, he has taken refuge in Me alone as the highest goal. At the end of innumerable births, the man of realisation takes refuge in Me, considering that Vasudeva as everything for him. Such a saint is exceedingly rare."

Health is wealth and both wear away

COVERNOTE

K. Nitya Kalyani

Health is wealth and conversely, ill-health is erosion of wealth. Conventional wisdom says this is where health insurance comes in. Until health insurance itself becomes a large drain on the pocket, ironically.

Things have been taking this direction in the last few years and now we have entered a stage where many are questioning the high premiums for reasonable levels of cover. And, by extension, wondering about health insurance economics and what it will become in the future. We will come back to this question in a bit but first let's take specific examples of premium increases.

Steep increase

A ₹10 lakh hospitalisation policy for a 45-year-old costs ₹20,000 to 25,000 today compared with about ₹18,000 to ₹20,000 a year ago. As much as 15% increase in a year is quite a shocker but still tame compared with the 25-30% increases for older people.



Catch 22: As much as 15% premium rise in a year is quite a shocker. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

Premium rates vary quite a bit by coverage, age, location and definitely insurance company, but the direction is clear, namely upwards, steeply. Before you think the premium jump is due to age 45 when you enter a new slab with higher rates, that was the case until last year. Annual increases have started across insurers and there are differentiations by zone as well.

Rising medical inflation

The reason offered is rising costs, centrally, medical inflation which is reportedly about 15% in recent years. The customer is still left wondering where this is all going. Going by this trend, in six or seven years our 45-year-olds would be paying double the premium for the same coverage. Or, her premium today will get her only half the sum insured. (Today's 45-year-old, at 52 will be looking at a more intimidating premium situation!).

All this if today's morbidity trends remain the same. Cancer diagnoses are growing, as are lifestyle diseases and God forbid another pandemic.

Sure, top-up policies help increase coverage for relatively much lower premiums and has been the portfolio tweak many have taken. It has taken the heat off those who want higher coverage but cringe at the premium rates of basic hospitalisation policies. Coming back to the basic policy, questioning the worth of insurance is an inadequate response. What about the cost of medical care WITHOUT insurance? Here is a creative idea – suggested in CoverNote a couple of years ago – which is now becoming the topic of family conversations and even decisions. Why not have only a top-up cover with a ₹10 lakh threshold and desired sum insured and be ready with funds to meet the first ₹10 lakh?

I know families that opted for this. Perhaps because paying an average of ₹1,00,000 a year for a ₹10 lakh policy for 10 years with no claim means you have paid the entire sum insured as premium and are set to keep paying.

Also, perhaps as they were denied hospitalisation cover due to age or medical reasons and they did not have much of a choice. In this situation, the top-up policy takes care of peak risk and the emergency medical fund pays bills of up to ₹10 lakh. Can this work? Yes and No. Let us see some scenarios in the next installment of CoverNote.

(The writer is a business journalist specialising in insurance & corporate history.)



ILLUSTRATION—SAAI

The retirement trap India is walking into unprepared

India is entering a phase where ageing, healthcare, personal finance will become deeply interconnected public issues; retirement can no longer be limited to tax-saving instruments

TWILIGHT ZONE

Vishwajeet Goel

India is growing older, at a pace most households are financially unprepared for. As per the United Nations Population Fund (UNFPA), almost one of five Indians will be over the age of 60 by 2050. The elderly population in India is likely to rise from about 15 crore today to more than 34 crore over the next three decades. At the same time, healthcare costs continue to rise sharply, while inflation steadily chips away at household savings.

Yet, retirement planning in India still largely operates on assumptions built for another era.

We are living longer

Better healthcare access, improved sanitation, rising incomes and medical advancements have helped Indians live longer than previous generations.

But the longer people live, the more years they must fund without a regular income. For most people retirement calculations are based on current spends than future costs.

A family spending ₹75,000/month today may believe a few crores will comfortably sustain retirement. But inflation changes the picture dramatically. Even with moderate inflation, everyday expenses can multiply several times over two or three decades. The impact becomes even sharper in healthcare.

In recent years, medical inflation in India has stayed at 12-14%, much higher than the overall inflation. Treatment can now cost a chunk of retirement savings.

This is why retirement planning can no longer rely on traditional savings instruments. India needs stronger pension participation and long-term retirement-focused investing habits. Instruments such as the National Pension System (NPS) encourage sustained retirement planning via regulated and relatively low-cost structure. Its flexibility across equity, government securities and debt allocation allows investors to gradually align risk with age and retirement goals. More importantly, NPS addresses the absence of a structured pension culture outside of government employment.

In recent years, medical inflation in India has stayed between 12-14%, significantly higher than overall inflation. Treatment can now use a huge chunk of retirement savings.

India is witnessing a rapid rise in chronic conditions such as diabetes, hypertension and cardiac disorders which are long-duration illnesses requiring continuous medication, diagnostics, follow-up care and, in many cases, repeated hospitalisation.

While earlier genera-

Even with moderate inflation, everyday expenses can multiply several times over two or three decades. The impact becomes even sharper in healthcare.

tions often associated retirement with reduced spending, modern retirees may experience the opposite. Healthcare, assisted living, home care support, diagnostics and medicines can become recurring monthly expenses changing the role of health insurance in household financial planning. Health cover today is increasingly becoming central to retirement protection. Without adequate coverage, even disciplined long-term savings can erode quickly after a major medical event.

Starting early

The advantage of starting early in instruments such as NPS is the ability to build a retirement corpus gradually over decades while benefiting from compounding and professional fund management. For younger earners especially, time is the biggest asset. Small but consistent contributions made early can potentially create significantly larger retirement outcomes compared with delayed investing later.

Traditional retirement strategies are not able to keep pace with realities.

Fixed deposits, long

considered the safest retirement instrument, often fail to generate inflation-beating post-tax returns over long periods. Realty is illiquid and does not always provide reliable rental income. Pension cover in India is also limited.

At the same time, Indian society is changing. Urbanisation, migration, nuclear families and changing career patterns mean many retirees may no longer have the same family-support structures similar to earlier generations. Financial independence during retirement is an economic and a social necessity.

Starting early allows compounding to work over decades rather than years.

But retirement planning cannot be reduced to chasing market returns or accumulating the largest corpus. The larger objective is sustainability. People need savings that can survive inflation, market cycles and rising healthcare costs over long retirement periods.

India is entering a phase where ageing, healthcare, and personal finance will become deeply interconnected public issues. It's retirement conversation can no longer remain limited to tax-saving investments or fixed deposits.

The challenge is, how does a country prepare millions of people to financially sustain lives becoming longer, more expensive and medically more demanding? This would define the future of retirement planning in India.

(The writer is Head, Pensionbazaar)

Investing in gold and silver

THINKINVESTOR

Geopolitical tensions around the world have made gold and silver important assets to have in one's investment portfolio. But you must be mindful of differences between the two assets.

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

You would have observed how gold and silver prices have moved in recent times. It is also highly likely you gained from the price movements over the last year. With gold prices near record highs and silver prices very volatile, many appear undecided on the next course of action on the two metals. Should you buy now or wait for a dip? If so, should you buy physical or financial asset? Here, we discuss why market timing on gold and silver exchange traded funds (ETFs) is optimal.

Market timing?

The important decision you should make is whether to buy the physical asset or its financial equivalent viz. ETFs. It is optimal to invest in ETFs for two reasons. One, it is operationally efficient to buy and sell ETFs. And two, gold and silver ETFs closely track the spot price of the underlying metal. True, these ETFs trade at a premium to spot price but you may be able to capture a similar premium when you sell the ETF. Selling price of 24-carat physical gold is typically lower than its spot price.

The question of whether you should buy ETF units now or wait for a dip depends on how you invest in gold and silver and manage the positions. Typically, gold and silver form part of satellite portfolio within the core-satellite framework. In this framework, the core portfolio is goal-based and the satellite is trading portfolio, geared to capturing short-term price fluctuations in the market. That means you must be comfortable with market timing. To do this, you must be good at reading price charts – applying technical analysis. Otherwise, you could buy such research from investment professionals. Another choice would be to set up short-term systematic investment plans (SIPs) and take profit whenever the investment generates predefined absolute gains. This choice, however, removes market timing out of the decision process.

Conclusion

The geopolitical tensions around the world have made both gold and silver important assets to have in one's investment portfolio. But you must be mindful of the difference between the two assets. Gold is typically considered as safe haven during global crisis (referred to as flight to quality). Also, central banks across the world invest in gold to build reserves. Silver is primarily an input in manufacturing processes. So, their returns and price volatility may not always be similar.

(The author offers training programmes for individuals to manage their personal investments)

Personal Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	Loan amount 1 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
HDFC Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to Rs 6,500
Tata Capital	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Flat Rs. 99
State Bank of India	10.00-15.00	10,624-11,895	2,125-2,379	Up to 1.50% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
ICICI Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 2%
Bank of Baroda *	10.15-18.00	10,660-12,697	2,132-2,539	Up to 2% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Axis Bank	8.95 onwards	10,367 onwards	2,073 onwards	Up to 2%
Kotak Mahindra Bank	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Up to 5%
Bank of India	10.85-16.15	10,834-12,199	2,167-2,440	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 250; Max. Rs 15,000)
Canara Bank	9.70-15.15	10,550-11,934	2,110-2,387	0.25% (Rs 500 - Rs 2,500)
Punjab National Bank	10.25-16.80	10,685-12,373	2,137-2,475	Up to 1%
HSBC Bank	9.75 onwards	10,562 onwards	2,112 onwards	Up to 2%
Federal Bank	11.75 - 18.99	11,059 - 12,968	2,212 - 2,594	0.25%-1%
Union Bank of India	8.90 - 12.65	10,355-11,287	2,071-2,257	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 7,500)
Bajaj Finserv	10.00-30.00	10,624-16,177	2,125-3,235	Up to 3.93%
Punjab & Sind Bank	9.60-13.85	10,525-11,595	2,105-2,319	0.50%-1%
Indian Overseas Bank	10.25 onwards	10,685 onwards	2,137 onwards	Up to 0.75%
UCO Bank	9.95 - 13.20	10,611-11,428	2,122-2,286	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 750)
IDFC FIRST Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 3.5%
Bank of Maharashtra	8.75-13.55	10,319-11,518	2,064-2,304	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Central Bank of India	11.25 onwards	10,934 onwards	2,187 onwards	Up to 1%
IndusInd Bank	10.49 onwards	10,744 onwards	2,149 onwards	Up to 3.5% (2% for instant personal loans for limited period)

*Interest concession of 0.10% to customers opting for group credit life insurance.

Car Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
Union Bank of India	7.50-10.00	10,019 - 10,684	Up to Rs 1,000
Punjab National Bank	7.60-10.70	10,043 - 10,797	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 1,500)
Bank of Baroda	7.60 - 11.35	10,043 - 10,959	Up to Rs. 2,000
Canara Bank	7.45-11.45	10,007 - 10,984	50% waiver on [0.25% (Rs 1,000 - Rs 5,000)]
Bank of India	7.60-12.55	10,043 - 11,262	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 10,000)
UCO Bank	7.35-10.00	9,983 - 10,624	0.5% (Max. Rs 5,000)
State Bank of India	8.80 - 9.85	10,331 - 10,587	Rs 750 - Rs 1,500
IDBI Bank	7.75-9.30	10,078 - 10,452	Rs 2,500
Bank of Maharashtra*	7.45-11.75	10,007 - 11,059	0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Indian Overseas Bank	7.55-12.00	10,031 - 11,122	NIL
ICICI Bank	8.35 onwards	10,222 onwards	Up to 2%
HDFC Bank	8.15 onwards	10,174 onwards	Up to 0.5% (Rs. 3,500 - Rs. 8,000)
Karnataka Bank	8.02-11.52	10,143 - 11,001	Up to 0.60% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 11,000)
Federal Bank	7.60-9.00	10,198 onwards	1% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 50,000)
Punjab and Sind Bank**	7.50-14.00	10,019 - 11,634	0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Indian Bank	7.50-9.65	10,019 - 10,513	Rs. 1,200
Central Bank of India	7.60-9.30	10,043 - 10,452	0.50%(Rs. 2,000 - Rs. 20,000)

*0.25% interest rate concession for home loan borrowers, other customers with at least 6 months of banking relationship

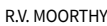
**Concession of up to 50% on processing fee for PSB Apna Vahan Sugam.

Rates and charges as on June 3

Source: Paisabazaar.com

Send queries on personal finance and investing to the moneywise@thehindu.co.in ID. Our experts in personal finance will respond to select queries, but will not give specific recommendations for investment in a particular mutual fund, share or fixed deposit.

Have to work on our process of taking reviews: Afghanistan coach



Women's T20 World Cup takes shape with captains' carnival



Former umpire Vikram Raju, who officiated tied Test, passes away



Animesh breaches 200m CWG mark, wins silver in Taipei City



Manav impresses as India has Afghanistan on the mat

The left-arm spinner's three-wicket haul leaves the visitor reeling at 113 for five, 451 runs in the red, after the host declares its first innings at 564 for eight; speedster Saleem scalps six

Vivek Krishnan
NEW CHANDIGARH

Our time to shine: Manav showcased his discipline and guile, while Saleem worked hard for his spoils. R.V. MOORTHY

It was a treat to watch Manav bowl: Washington

Vivek Krishnan
NEW CHANDIGARH

Quick off the blocks: Manav needed only four deliveries to get his first Test wicket. R.V. MOORTHY



Lone-ranger: Saleem stood out in an otherwise disappointing show from Afghanistan. R.V. MOORTHY

Important to be the same person as before: Shreyas

Amol Karhadkar
MUMBAI

Big responsibility: Shreyas has been entrusted with the task of leading India in the new T20I World Cup cycle. FILE PHOTO: K.R. DEEPAK

Shreyas suggested that the competitive culture shaped not only his crick-
eting journey but also his
appetite for responsibility.
“Learning or winning is
secondary, but (its about
having) more fun growing
up. The more competitive
nature you have, especially
while you play cricket or
any other sport in general,
the better it is,” he said. “I
think that takes you to
another level and you want
to take that sort of respon-
sibility”.

INBRIEF



Marc wins Hungarian MotoGP for weekend sweep

Reigning World champion Marc Marquez won on a Sunday for the first time this season as he held off young Spanish compatriot Pedro Acosta to take the Hungarian MotoGP. Francesco Bagnaia finished a distant third while the top two in the standings, Aprilia pair Marco Bezzeccchi and Jorge Martin, crashed out on the first corner.

Second West Indies-Sri Lanka one-dayer washed out

The second One-Day International between the West Indies and Sri Lanka was abandoned because of rain on Saturday in Kingston without a ball being bowled. Sri Lanka leads the three-match series 1-0 after winning the first match by 41 runs. West Indies had earlier won the toss and elected to bowl first before unrelenting rain forced the umpires to call off the match.

Argentina centre-back Balerdi out of World Cup

Argentina's central defender Leonardo Balerdi has been ruled out of the World Cup with a calf injury, the world champion announced on Saturday. The 27-year-old has suffered a muscle injury in his right leg. Argentina has not yet named a replacement and will kick off its tournament on June 17 against Algeria in Kansas City.

Iraq names Makenzie as replacement for Yahya

Iraq has called up Ahmed Hassan Makenzie to its FIFA World Cup squad to replace Ahmed Yahya, who has been ruled out of the tournament with a hamstring injury. "Based on the medical report, head coach Graham Arnold has decided to call up Makenzie and register him in the final squad for the finals in place of Yahya," the national team said in a statement on X. The tournament marks Iraq's first appearance at the World Cup since its sole participation 40 years ago. It is set to compete in Group I alongside France, Senegal and Norway.



Iran squad arrives in Mexico ahead of the World Cup

Iran's football team arrived in Mexico on Sunday morning for training ahead of the FIFA World Cup, before three group matches in the United States later this month. Ehsan Hajsafi was the first player to exit the plane with markings for German charter airline USC, which arrived around 5.05 a.m. The team's participation in the World Cup has been complicated by the Iran war. Problems with processing visas earlier led Iran to move its training base from Tucson, Arizona, to Tijuana, Mexico, which is on the border with California. The team has been training in the Turkish city of Antalya. It flew directly to Mexico on a private jet from the Mediterranean city.

Former captain Tamim elected as BCB president

Former national team captain Tamim Iqbal has been elected as the president of the Bangladesh Cricket Board (BCB). Tamim has previously served as head of its ad-hoc committee. "Tamim was elected unopposed at a board meeting held following Sunday's BCB elections, having secured the highest number of votes in the Club Category contest," said BCB official Rabeed Imam.

LIVE TELECAST

India vs Afghanistan: One-off Test, day 3, Star Sports 2 & JioHotstar, 9.30 a.m.
Women's T20 World Cup (warm-up): India vs West Indies, Star Sports 1 & JioHotstar, 2.30 p.m.
West Indies vs Sri Lanka: 3rd ODI, FanCode, 1 a.m. (Tuesday)

You cannot judge a player by his World Cup performances alone

The Portuguese superstar believes fitness is more mental than physical; the 41-year-old stresses that he doesn't care about outside noise

INTERVIEW

Cristiano Ronaldo

Cristiano Ronaldo, the global icon of football, reflects on the past and speaks about the future in a freewheeling chat. **Excerpts:**

You are set to appear in your sixth World Cup...

That says I have survived the test of time! My first World Cup was in 2006 in Germany, and I shall be there in the United States to complete 20 years of playing the tournament. It was a great feeling to score at least one goal in each of the five tournaments I have played so far.

Football is said to be all about scoring goals and you are the highest scorer!

Yes, I know the numbers and the numbers don't lie! I took the challenge of playing in different leagues in top European countries and scored. Now I am playing in Saudi Arabia and



Upbeat: Ronaldo feels Portugal has the perfect blend of youth and experience to go the distance. AP

scoring goals here, too. It's satisfying. Moreover, I have been scoring for my country at the same rate as well. Feels nice!

Experts feel Portugal has a bright chance to win the World Cup this time...

We have a great team. Our footballers have been playing well in top European leagues for so many years. The team has a perfect blend of youth and expe-

rience. So, why not? We had always given our best in the last 20 years, but it did not click somehow. We shall be having another go this time. The spirit of the team is high as always. Let's see what is in store for us in the United States.

What are the secrets for your supreme fitness at 41?

It's more mental than physical! I want to improve every time. That motivates

me to be at the best of my abilities. To achieve that, I am ready to do everything. Football is a lovely game, and I want to continue playing at the top level as long as possible. The hunger for success is eternal which keeps me going. Being a true professional, I know the things I must do and I follow the routine, make sacrifices. At the end, it gives me immense pleasure to be on the field and contribute to the team's cause.

Ruthless England bundles out New Zealand, takes 1-0 lead

CRICKET

Associated Press
LONDON



Sealing it: Atkinson casting Henry signalled England's 115-run win. REUTERS

England wrapped up a 115-run victory over New Zealand before lunch on day four of the first Test at Lord's on Sunday, marking a positive start to its Baz-ball reset after the Ashes humiliation Down Under.

Resuming on 55 for five and requiring 254 for an unlikely win, New Zealand lost its remaining five wickets inside the first two hours of play and was dismissed for 138.

England pacer Gus Atkinson finished with team-best figures of five for 30 on what has been a bowler-friendly surface at the home of cricket that has

seen 24 batters out bowled or lbw, and no spinners getting a single delivery.

Glenn Phillips was New Zealand's top scorer (44 n.o., 52b, 7x4, 1x6).

This first Test series of the summer has been regarded as a fresh start for

England and its under-pressure leadership after a 1-4 loss to Australia.

The scores: England 140 & 226 bt New Zealand 113 & 138 in 40.3 overs (Conway 41, Phillips 44 n.o., Atkinson 5/30, Robinson 2/38, Tongue 2/48); **POM:** Robinson.

AROUND THE CITY

Sudha Shah XI gets the better of Khalili XI

Sudha Shah XI registered a five-wicket victory over Fowzieh Khalili XI in the Freyer-Thiruvallur DCA Women's League match on Sunday.

The scores: Fowzieh Khalili XI 174/9 in 40 overs (C. Yaazhini Evangelin 64, M. Jeni Plautila 3/30) lost to Sudha Shah XI 177/5 in 33.1 overs (V. Hashini 56, M. Jeni Plautila 35).

GFCA clinches under-12 crown

GFCA defeated SJCA by four wickets in the final to emerge champion of the 20th Freyer International Logistics-LMCA Trophy under-12 tournament on Sunday.

T.J. Srinivasaraj, president, TNCA, Dr. J. Radhakrishnan, IAS, Addl. Chief Secretary, TNEB & TNPDCL, and P.G. Subramanian, principal, Bhavan's Rajaji Vidyashram, Kilpauk, were present on the occasion.

The scores (final): SJCA 127/9 in 25 overs (Sachin Sai 33) lost to GFCA 128/6 in 24.4 overs (S. Lishan 3/18).



Perfect finish: The GFCA team, winner of the Freyer International Logistics-LMCA Trophy u-12 tournament, with the dignitaries.



Moment to cherish: Rajesh Ramesh honoured during the KESPA-HITS World Cup Football Quiz. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

MSN Lions posts facile victory

MSN Lions cruised to a six-wicket triumph over

Sachin Cricket Foundation in the semifinal clash of the 41st SMCA Champions Trophy tournament on Sunday. In the other last-four fixture, MSN Stars inflicted

Amol Karhadkar MUMBAI

As teenagers spending endless hours at the nets of Shivaji Park Gymkhana in the early 2010s, Shreyas Iyer and Tushar Deshpande had a simple wager to make practice sessions more competitive.

If Deshpande's pace bowling got the better of Shreyas' stylish strokeplay, the batter would buy him an egg sandwich at the gymkhana canteen. If Shreyas dominated, Deshpande paid the bill.

More than a decade later, the stakes have changed.

"Of course the friendly matches will continue in the nets but for a different prize, the prize will be the World Cup (in 2028),"



Shreyas. AFP

Deshpande said on Saturday.

Deshpande believes Shreyas' rise from the maidans of Shivaji Park to becoming India's T20I captain hardly surprises those who know him closely.

"Everyone knows he's a brilliant player, brilliant cricketer and a great leader," Deshpande said. "He has shown that for Punjab Kings as well. Winning the IPL for KKR, taking Delhi Capitals to the final when I

was a part of Delhi Capitals. It's been a great journey for him, and I wish him well."

While Shreyas' appointment dominated conversations, Deshpande himself continues searching for consistency in opportunities. Despite enjoying an impressive start to his maiden season with Rajasthan Royals in IPL 2026, the Mumbai pacer featured in only six matches.

"Personally it was disappointing to get only six games even though I bowled a superb last over under pressure in the first game, but it all boils down to the team balance and the team's requirements," Deshpande said.

"Everyone in Mumbai knows what I can do with the bat, too".

Zuccaro claims the H.H. Krishnaraja Wadiyar Cup

BENGALURU: P. Shroff trained Zuccaro (G. Vivek up) won the H.H. Krishnaraja Wadiyar Cup (1,600m), the feature event of the races held here on Sunday (June 7).

The winner is owned by Five Stars Shipping Co Pvt Ltd rep. by Mr. K.N. Dhunijbhoy, Mr. Z.K. Dhunijbhoy, Ms. Anosha Meyers, Mr. Vipsi R. Patel, Mr. A.S. Narielwala, Mr. Eruch Adi Mody, Miss. Anita J. Captain, Mr. Dinshaw P. Adenwalla & Mrs. Jasmine D. Adenwalla.

THE RESULTS
1. MYSTIC MEMORY PLATE (1,400M): GLORIOUS STRIDES (Neeraj) 1, Eagle Eye (Akshay K) 2, Hazel (Antony) 3 and Sicyon (Yash) 4. 1/2, 2-3/4 and 2. Im 25.52s. Rs. 41 (w), 12, 11 and 17 (p), SHP: 31, THP: 38, FP: 140, Q: 50, Trinella: 376/245, Exacta: 741/224. Favourite: Eagle Eye.

Owners: Mr. Daulat Chhabria, Mr. Teja Gollapudi & Mr. Ashok Ranpise. Trainer: S. Narreddy.
2. NANDI PLATE (1,400M): STAR COMET (Akshay K) 1, Southern Force (Antony) 2, Elveden (Aleemuddin) 3 and Dynamic Force (S. Sachin) 4. 2-3/4, 1-1/4 and 4. Im 26.74s. Rs. 78 (w), 18, 14 and 23 (p), SHP: 38, THP: 54, FP: 304, Q: 93, Trinella: 915/485, Exacta: 2,948/1,263. Favourite: Dynamic Force.

Owner: Mr. Kapil Dev M. Trainer: Aravind G.
3. CNN FAMILY AND FRIENDS LEGACY TROPHY (1,200M): REGAL BEAUTY (Sandesh) 1, Sensuous (Suraj) 2, Legacy Field (Akshay K) 3 and Heimrich (Sai Kiran) 4. 1, 3/4 and Nose. Im 13.69s. Rs. 31 (w), 10, 19 and 14 (p), SHP: 50, THP: 35, FP: 254, Q: 143, Trinella: 483/130, Exacta: 3,933/1,555. Favourite:

Legacy Field. Owners: Mr. Chaduranga Kanthraj Urs, Mr. Aditya P. Thackersey & Manjri Horse Breeders' Farm Pvt Ltd. Trainer: Darius Byramji.

4. SPEAKER'S CUP (1,200M): RIEKO (S. Sachin) 1, Flight On (Akshay K) 2, Power Of Beauty (Aruil) 3 and Victoria Doreasani (L.A. Rozario) 4. 2-1/2, 2-1/4 and 1-1/4. Im 12.36s. Rs. 16 (w), 12, 16 and 27 (p), SHP: 42, THP: 74, FP: 71, Q: 45, Trinella: 658/384, Exacta: 5,153/1,152. Favourite: Reiko.

Owner: Mr. P. Arun Kumar. Trainer: Pradeep Annaiah.
5. H.H. KRISHNARAJA WADIYAR CUP (1,600M): ZUCCARO (G. Vivek) 1, Mayne Magic (Antony) 2, Siege Courageous (Suraj) 3 and Positano (Sandesh) 4. 2-1/2, 1 and 1-1/2. Im 40.97s. Rs. 14 (w), 14 and 15 (p), SHP: 25, THP: 29, FP: 37, Q: 29, Trinella: 54/16, Exacta: 86/56. Favourite: Zuccaro.

Owners: Five Stars Shipping Co Pvt Ltd rep. by Mr. K.N. Dhunijbhoy, Mr. Z.K. Dhunijbhoy, Ms. Anosha Meyers, Mr. Vipsi R. Patel, Mr. A.S. Narielwala, Mr. Eruch Adi Mody, Miss. Anita J. Captain, Mr. Dinshaw P. Adenwalla & Mrs. Jasmine D. Adenwalla. Trainer: P. Shroff.

6. ASTOUNDING PLATE (1,600M): TURF PARADISE (A. Asbar) 1, Imperador (Vishal) 2, Pledge (Akshay K) 3 and Amazing Stride (Antony) 4. 6-1/2, 1-3/4 and 4. Im 41.83s. Rs. 32 (w), 15, 26 and 11 (p), SHP: 68, THP: 37, FP: 861, Q: 568, Trinella: 1,332/285, Exacta: 6,137/4,734. Favourite: Pledge.
Owner: Mrs. S Jagadamba. Trainer: V. Lokanath.
Jackpot: Rs 2,768; Runner-up: 231; Mini Jackpot: 553; Treble (6): 925; (ii): 154.

Zverev wins a dramatic finale, ends wait for his maiden Slam

The second seed edges Cobolli in a five-setter to become the first German man to clinch a Major since Becker at the Australian Open in 1996; the Italian 10th seed produces a spirited fightback before losing steam in the decider

FRENCH OPEN

Agence France-Presse
PARIS

Alexander Zverev finally secured his maiden Grand Slam title with a dramatic five-set victory over Italy's Flavio Cobolli in the French Open final on Sunday.

The second seed became the first German man to win a Major tournament since Boris Becker at the 1996 Australian Open with a 6-1, 4-6, 6-4, 6-7(5), 6-1 win after four hours and 16 minutes on Court Philippe Chatrier.

It was Zverev's fourth Grand Slam final and second at Roland-Garros after some heartbreaking near misses in his career.

Cobolli, the 10th seed, was bidding to become the first Italian man to win the French Open in 50 years.

The 24-year-old had never even played a Slam semifinal before, let alone a final, after his last-four opponent Matteo Arnaldi withdrew from the tournament through illness.

Nervy affair

Both players appeared to struggle with nerves at various points in the match, especially Cobolli during an error-strewn first set. But Zverev's greater experience showed in a deciding set that was far tenser than the scoreline suggested, as he managed



Mission accomplished: Zverev is relieved at realising his dream of being a Grand Champion in his fourth final. REUTERS

Alexander rules

2 Since 128-player draws were introduced at all four Majors in 1988, Zverev is the second man after Johansson (Australian Open 2002) to win a maiden Slam without defeating a top-10 opponent en route

3 Zverev is the third German man to win a Major after Becker and Stich

4 The fourth man to clinch a Grand Slam, Masters 1000, the season-ending championship and the Olympic gold after Agassi, Murray and Djokovic

25 Only Lendl (41) and Muster (29) have won

more career titles at the ATP level before bagging their first Major crown

32 The number of five-set matches in Paris this year. Only 1992 and 2001 (33 each) had more

41 Zverev won a first Slam in his 41st main draw appearance. Only Ivani-sevic (48, Wimbledon 2001) has taken more

125 No player has figured in more matches at a Major before winning his first than Zverev



Compiled by ANIRUDH VELAMURI

Antonelli extends run of victories to five races

FORMULA ONE

Reuters
MONACO

Formula One championship leader Kimi Antonelli stayed ice-cool to win a chaotic Monaco Grand Prix and extend his run of victories this season to five on Sunday.

The 19-year-old Italian built a commanding lead after starting from pole in his Mercedes but that evaporated after a late red flag to inspect a crumbling surface at the final corner following a crash that took out Ferrari's Charles Leclerc.

After a delay of around 40 minutes while repairs were carried out, the race resumed with a standing start but Antonelli remained unfazed as he became the youngest ever winner of the iconic race.

Ferrari's Lewis Hamilton was runner-up for the second successive GP with Red Bull's Isack Hadjar provisionally third, although he was one of a number of drivers under investigation for a variety of infringements.

Hamilton, who equalled the late Ayrton Senna's eight Monaco podiums, moved above Antonelli's teammate George Russell into second place in the standings, 66 points behind Antonelli.

"It's been an incredible weekend and an incredible race," said Antonelli, who was not even born the last time an Italian won the Monaco GP – Jarno Trulli in 2004. "We had incredible pace and it all came so natural and that gave me the confidence to push."



1 Antonelli (19y 9m 13d) becomes the youngest to win in Monaco, breaking Hamilton's 2008 record (23y 4m 18d)	10 The teenager is the 10th driver to secure five wins in a row. Every other driver who has done so has gone on to win the title that season
1 The Italian is the youngest to record a Grand Slam (pole position, leading every lap, fastest lap and race win)	13 Mercedes overtakes Ford Cosworth for most wins in Monaco
1 Antonelli is the first Italian to win in Monaco after Trulli in 2004	15 After six Grands Prix, Antonelli has made the best start to a season since Vettel in 2011
8 Hamilton equals Senna for most podiums in Monaco	95 Albon equals Mansell for most starts with Williams
9 Antonelli and Hamilton together have as many podium finishes this season as the rest of the grid combined	100 Hamilton becomes the first driver to stand on the podium 100 times in races he did not win

Compiled by Anirudh Velamuri

A year after finishing last on his F1 debut at Monaco, Antonelli showed incredible poise to shrug off the red flag drama that meant he effectively had to win two races.

"I wasn't super keen on re-starting but once the notification came out I just gathered my emotions and re-focused again. Once I got away and was P1 into the first corner I could enjoy the last few laps".

The results:
1. Kimi Antonelli (Mercedes) 2h:23m:31.243s; 2. Lewis Hamilton (Ferrari) + 6.271s; 3. Isack Hadjar (Red Bull Racing) 23.394; 4. Oscar Piastri (McLaren) 24.261; 5. Liam Lawson (Racing Bulls) 26.553; 6. Arvid Lindblad

(Racing Bulls) 29.010; 7. Pierre Gasly (Alpine) 30.369; 8. Alexander Albon (Williams) 33.413; 9. Esteban Ocon (Haas) 37.140; 10. Fernando Alonso (Aston Martin) 41.899; 11. Gabriel Bortoleto (Audi) 42.748; 12. George Russell (Mercedes) 43.353; 13. Nico Hulkenberg (Audi) 44.102; 14. Franco Colapinto (Alpine) 48.964; 15. Sergio Perez (Cadillac) 49.153.

DNF: Carlos Sainz (Williams); Charles Leclerc (Ferrari); Lance Stroll (Aston Martin); Lando Norris (McLaren); Oliver Bearman (Haas); Valtteri Bottas (Cadillac); Max Verstappen (Red Bull Racing).

Standings: Drivers: 1. Antonelli 156; 2. Hamilton 90; 3. Russell 88; 4. Leclerc 75; 5. Piastri 60.

Constructors: 1. Mercedes 244; 2. Ferrari 165; 3. McLaren 118; 4. Red Bull Racing 72; 5. Alpine 41.

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FLICKR/NORWAYCHES

Grandmaster Praggnanandhaa says every tournament is unique in its own way; the 20-year-old admits that he will have to prioritise taking breaks to ensure he isn't burnt out; the Indian, who had a tough time at the Candidates, feels he is someone who quickly recovers from disappointments

INTERVIEW

R. Praggnanandhaa

C. Shyam Sundar

He's been around for so long that one forgets that he is just 20. Indian Grandmaster R. Praggnanandhaa's rise has been steadily spectacular.

Having been drawn to chess quite early, his growth was impressive. Winning became a habit for him and the International Master title at the age of 10 turned the spotlight on him firmly. He has come a long way since, pursuing excellence in the sport with unwavering focus and dedication.

The Chennai GM was a hugely popular player at the Norway Chess 2026 along with compatriot and World champion D. Gukesh with fans swarming the duo to get pictures taken and for autographs.

Praggnanandhaa or simply Pragg as the chess fraternity and fans like to call him, took time off to share his thoughts with the Indian media about life on the road, the pressures of top-flight sport, hobbies and friends in a freewheeling chat. Excerpts:

The strangest place you have played chess in? You are playing a library right now...

I can't think of one, probably the library. Usually a library is calm... but here there is always something happening in the background

In this tournament, you defeated World No. 1 Magnus Carlsen twice... What do you think about that?

I think everyone is strong here, it's not just about Magnus, there are also other strong players, so you have to do well against everyone, I didn't have good moments early in the tournament.

Given your busy schedule, what facet of the game motivates you to give your best?

I enjoy playing the game, so whenever I sit at the board, I just enjoy it, so I try to give my best. Nothing specific, I think every tournament is different, you are facing different opponents, different formats, so every tournament is exciting in its own way.

At this stage of your career, what is it that most interests you about chess?

I think it just depends on the tournament.... like here the format is so exciting that I am just happy to play, also the players are super strong, I mean there are tournaments where the goal is simple, just to try to win the tournament.

Which are these tournaments that you are just there to enjoy?

It just depends on the tournament, it just depends on my mood, how I feel before it, how I feel during the tournament and all these things.

You played around 16 tournaments in 2025. Is there a conscious idea to maybe play less tournaments?

Yeah, that is something that I decided I will try to do (play less), try to have breaks in between. Last year... even though the results went my way, it was a bit too much to play... so much of chess. I'm still probably going to play almost all the (big) tournaments, but I'll probably skip the EWC (Esports World Cup) and all these other tournaments. I mean at some point you just have to prioritise.

Did you feel that playing so many tournaments kind of affected your tournament play at some point because you didn't have time to reset, you didn't have time to retool in terms of tactics and strategies and things like that?

For sure, I think at some point you are just burnt out, you don't have energy like even if you have physical energy, you just don't have the mental energy to do the same thing pretty much every tournament, same routine and everything gets tiring at some point. It just becomes automatic that you just don't enjoy it anymore, it just happens. So, that's why I think these breaks are important.

When did you feel burnt out or feel why am I playing so much?

I can't really say the exact moment but at some point like I was, I counted this like in three months I travelled to seven countries, which I think is too much for anyone... Look, one is not going there to just have a look at the place, you are going there to fight in every tournament and all these tournaments are super strong. It is mentally tiring, but you know it's me that signed up for all these tournaments so I have to take it whatever that comes.

You became an International Master at a young age and 10 years down the line you are one of the



strongest chess players in the world, so how do you look at being a role model...

I don't really think too much about it. I just do what I do, I just try to play a game, but it's nice to see that people look up to a chess player and want to take up chess... you know whenever there is some kid coming to take a picture or for an autograph I try to do my best, I try to give them a little bit of time, so yeah, I think it's great. When one starts, they look up to someone and get started. So, it's nice that people are looking at not just me but also the other Indian players too.

Has there ever been a time in the recent past, when you thought maybe I could have had a normal childhood, school, and finished college?

You have to give (up) certain things for certain things. I don't really regret it,

but I would have loved to have some school friends or college friends. But when I'm going for something much bigger, I'm happy with how things are.

When you are in Chennai, who are the people that you call to maybe go to the beach or cinema. Is it someone like Gukesh or Arjun (Erigaisi) or others?

No, I think we look at each other too much in tournaments... (laughs). If I am going out when I am in Chennai, it's usually like my sister (R. Vaishali) is there, my family is there, they are the ones.

Don't you get to look at Vaishali as you play a lot of tournaments together..

As brother and sister, we have to look at each other in tournaments and at home too.. There is no escape. I have a few chess friends and we sometimes go out

to play some sports.

Do you think that Indian youngsters focus maybe too much on chess and is there too much pressure?

I can only answer from my part. At times, I do feel like I focus too much on chess. Certainly, I think having a different hobby could help chess as well. There are some things that I want to try in the future. There is nothing specific, it's just that sometimes you just read something and you are excited.

On the disappointment after missing out in the Candidates

Certainly that (disappointment of not doing well in Candidates) is something that I have to deal with because in the last two years I was thinking only about this cycle... I sort of gave everything for this. There was nothing else I was thinking about. You can also see from the tournaments I played last year that I was just going for this one spot in the FIDE circuit (to qualify for the Candidates). I have to try and get back to playing tournaments. I just want to play chess and chill (now). I don't want to think about the next two-year cycle.

How long does it take for you to recover from such disappointments, like the one in the Candidates

I am usually quick to recover from disappointments. And, I think, in this Candidates specifically like my sister (Vaishali) winning certainly helped me cope with my own disappointment.

You have a growing fan base in Taiwan though you have not played there... Any message for them?

I'm pleasantly surprised to hear that. It's nice to know that as you don't really hear Taiwan as a chess culture nation, so I think any country starting to grow a chess culture is great. I hope more tournaments will be held there and more kids will be coming up from there.

Do you use Artificial Intelligence (AI) in your training?

I wouldn't say I use proper AI, but of course I use engines and computers and they do play a vital role in opening preparation. But also you learn a lot from just looking at the engine, the way it thinks, the way it analyses and so on. I think everyone uses that.
(The writer is in Oslo at the invitation of Norway Chess).

Homo erectus fossil yields secrets long thought to be beyond genetics

That modern humans carry DNA fragments from two other members of the genus *Homo* raised the possibility that they may also harbour genetic material from other extinct human species; but in the 14 years since the Denisovan genome was published, no new genome from any other extinct human relative has been uncovered — until now

Arun Panchapakesan

For much of modern history, human evolution was thought to progress in linear fashion, with one species replacing another, one by one. The famous ‘ape turning to human’ cartoon illustrating a stooped primate gradually straightening into a modern man essentially captures this idea.

That picture began to change in the second half of the 19th century when scientists started to unearth human-like fossils. At the time, scientists used geological clues such as the depth at which a fossil was found and the rock layers surrounding it to determine the age of fossils. This method could establish which fossils were older or younger than others but did not reveal precise dates.

The timeline suggested an intriguing possibility, however. It appeared that these different kinds of humans had not followed one another in succession but had lived alongside each other. Radiometric dating techniques later confirmed this idea: multiple human species had coexisted on the earth at various points.

Series of surprises

In 2003, the Human Genome Project announced the first high-quality sequence of the human genome. Human beings finally possessed the secret to their own identity – the reason(s) they were unique. That sense of identity, however, proved to be short-lived.

In 2010, scientists published the genome of the Neanderthals, our closest extinct relatives. When they compared Neanderthal DNA with the genomes of living people, they uncovered a remarkable result. Most humans alive today carry around 1-2% Neanderthal DNA in their own genomes. In Africans, this percentage is slightly lower, but even their DNA is 0.3-0.5% Neanderthal.

The surprises did not end there. In 2012, scientists sequenced the genome of Denisovans, another human lineage, finding that some present-day populations, particularly in Oceania and parts of Southeast Asia, had 3-6% Denisovan DNA.

That we carry DNA fragments from two other members of the genus *Homo* raised the possibility that we may also harbour genetic material from other extinct human species. But in the 14 years since the Denisovan genome was published, no new genome from any other extinct human relative has been uncovered.

DNA after death

The difficulty lies in the nature of DNA itself. The moment an organism dies, its DNA begins to break down. Enzymes



Representative image of the bones of the *Homo erectus* fossil ‘Turkana Boy’, the most complete fossil of the species found to date. EINSAMER SCHÜTZE (CC BY-SA)

released from dying cells cut DNA into small pieces. Microbes and fungi invade the remains and further degrade the genetic material. Water and oxygen promote chemical reactions that further damage DNA. Then there are temperature fluctuations, solar radiation, and UV damage. Over a few tens of millennia, the DNA is reduced to a few small pieces.

To recover DNA from these ancient humans, scientists need to be very lucky. The specimen must have been exposed to cold, dry, and stable environments such as permafrost, frozen sediments, or the inside of a deep cave. This is very rare – and why only a small fraction of fossils contain usable DNA.

One such species whose DNA sequence has evaded us for a long time is *Homo erectus*, the species estimated to have originated over 2 million years ago and thought to be one of the first human relatives to spread widely across Africa, Europe, and Asia.

Acid etching

A recent study published in *Nature* has provided the first molecular sequences from *Homo erectus* fossils from China. Rather than attempting to recover DNA directly, the researchers extracted proteins preserved within the enamel of six *Homo erectus* teeth dated to around

4,00,000 years ago. Because proteins are the products of the DNA, their sequences can reveal portions of the underlying genetic information, providing a rare, albeit narrow, view into the genome of an extinct human species.

The method used to recover the genetic information is notable. Usually, recovering ancient DNA or proteins requires scientists to grind up part of a fossil, so museum curators are reluctant to permit such analyses, especially when there is no guarantee that usable genetic material will be recovered.

To overcome this problem, the researchers used acid etching, a technique where a small area of the tooth enamel is briefly exposed to a dilute acid solution, which dissolves microscopic amounts of tooth enamel and releases the proteins trapped within it. The fossil is left largely intact. Since tooth enamel is a highly mineralised tissue, it can trap and protect proteins for a long time.

The researchers proceeded to successfully recover enamel proteins from five male and one female *Homo erectus* individuals. When they compared the protein sequences with those of modern humans, Neanderthals, and Denisovans, they made two interesting discoveries.

First, all six *Homo erectus* individuals had a protein variant that has never been

found in any other known species in the genus *Homo*. Second, they carried another variant present in Denisovans. This suggests populations related to these Chinese *Homo erectus* may have interbred with Denisovans in East Asia.

Shared story

However, because the results come from only the enamel proteins and not the entire genome, they are not conclusive. It was long known that the Denisovan genome contains DNA from a much older species of the human lineage. While this study points to *Homo erectus* as a possible candidate, it does not prove it.

Nevertheless, the study represents an advance far beyond the information it has generated, which by itself is tiny. This is the first effort to recover meaningful molecular data from *Homo erectus* fossils, long thought to be beyond the reach of genetics.

Though Neanderthals, Denisovans, and others have vanished from the earth, traces of their existence endure within our DNA. The more we look, the more we find that the story of humans is not only ours: it is theirs as well.

(Arun Panchapakesan is an assistant professor at the Y.R. Gaitonde Centre for AIDS Research and Education, Chennai. arun.panchapakesan@gmail.com)

THE GIST

Radiometric dating techniques have confirmed that multiple human species had coexisted on the earth at various points

While the Human Genome Project in 2003 provided humans with a sense of unique identity, later studies showed the presence of Neanderthal and Denisovan DNA in the modern human genome

A recent study on enamel from *Homo erectus* teeth has revealed a protein variant never found before in the genus as well as another variant present in Denisovans

It was known that the Denisovan genome contains DNA from a much older species of human lineage and the study, while not conclusive, points to *Homo erectus* as a possible candidate

BIG SHOT



As part of the Wilderness Project, wildlife experts who visited Angola’s Lisima plateau in February have reported eight new species of dragonfly, three unknown grasshoppers, and some 60 new butterflies and moths in vivid hues. They have also found a spider species that fluoresces under ultraviolet light (shown). REUTERS

WHAT IS IT?

Pyroprocessing: heat shows the way

Vasudevan Mukunth

Pyroprocessing is a way to change a solid material physically or chemically using high temperature. It is a dry process and very energy-intensive. The three sectors that use it most are cement-making, metallurgy, and nuclear power.

Of these, cement-making uses pyroprocessing the most. First, finely ground limestone, clay and iron — the raw materials — are fed into a rotary kiln. As the temperature increases to 900° C, the limestone loses its carbon dioxide, and at around 1,450° C, the mix partly melts to form marble-sized nodules called clinker. The clinker is then ground to produce cement.

In metallurgy, pyroprocessing is used to extract metals from their ores in multiple stages. For example, sulphide ores are heated in air — or roasted — to convert them into metal oxides, like zinc sulphide. Smelting melts an ore to separate the metal from waste impurities called slag. Heating limestone to yield lime is likewise called calcining.

In the nuclear industry, pyroprocessing has a slightly different meaning. It is used to reprocess spent nuclear fuel, in techniques developed in the 1980s and 1990s. First, used nuclear fuel is broken up into pieces and placed in a salt bath — usually a mixture of lithium and potassium chlorides at 500° C or more. Then, an electric current is passed through the salt bath, causing



A rotary kiln is visible as the rust-coloured horizontal tube at the centre in this image of a cement plant in the U.S. GREG GOEBEL (CC BY-SA)

different elements to become separated depending on their electrochemical properties. Operators then recover the elements of interest in separate streams.

This form of pyroprocessing has been the subject of study in Japan, South Korea, and the U.S. and is used as part of programmes involving advanced fast reactors.

For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to science@thehindu.co.in with the subject ‘Daily page’

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Persons injured in violence that erupted in Somalia's capital

55 One person was killed and 55 were injured in political violence that erupted in Somalia's capital this week, according to a government statement on Sunday. President Hassan Sheikh Mohamud has sparked a fresh political crisis by announcing a one-year extension of his term, which had been due to expire on May 15. AFP

Share of grassland lost by Assam's Manas National park

60 in per cent. Assam's Manas National Park & Tiger Reserve rolled out the State's first grass nursery as it has lost more than 60% of the park's grasslands over the past 35 years. The nursery has been developed over an area of 7.5 bigha with financial support from the State Compensatory Afforestation Fund Management and Planning Authority. PTI

Deaths linked to unsafe use of pesticides in Rajasthan

535 As many as 535 farmers have died while using pesticides in Rajasthan between January 2024 and January 2026, according to information provided in response to a legislative assembly question. The agriculture department said that ₹5.10 crore in assistance was provided to the families of deceased farmers under the CM's farmer welfare scheme. PTI

Amount invested by Swiss firms in the U.S. after tariff deal

27 in \$ billion. Swiss companies invested \$27 billion in the U.S. between January and April, as Switzerland moves to fulfil a pledge to sharply increase investment following a tariff agreement with Washington, *NZZ am Sonntag* reported. The figure was contained in an internal email from the Swiss-American Chamber of Commerce to its members, it said. REUTERS

Number of fatalities reported during Char Dham Yatra

161 More than 31 lakh pilgrims have visited Uttarakhand since the Char Dham Yatra began in April, while 161 fatalities have been reported among the devotees during the ongoing pilgrimage season, officials said on Sunday. According to the latest report, Kedarnath Dham recorded the highest footfall with 11,05,676 pilgrims. PTI
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The Ordinance question before the SC

The Collegium's acceptance of an Ordinance that creates four additional judges' posts raises questions about judicial independence, security of tenure and the appearance of detachment from the executive; court has taken a calculated risk by staking its independence on the goodwill of the government and Parliament

LETTER & SPIRIT

V. Venkatesan

In February 1937, the President of the United States of America, Franklin D. Roosevelt, asked Congress to enlarge the nine-judge Supreme Court. He sought a new justice for each one past 70 who refused to retire, up to 15 in all. The Senate Judiciary Committee saw through it. It preferred “an independent Court, a fearless Court,” to one that bent “out of fear or sense of obligation to the appointing power.” The Senate refused, with 70 members voting against and 20 in favour, and the plan was dead.

In Delhi last week, five judges took the oath; three occupy chairs, that no statute has created. They sit because the President, by Ordinance, lifted the sanctioned strength from 34 to 38.

Ordinance-made seats

The five are fit for office: four sat as Chief Justices of High Courts, the fifth came from the bar. Their elevation is not the grievance; the manner of it is. The Ordinance was promulgated on May 16, when the Court sat at 32 against a sanctioned 34. Two lawful vacancies existed; two of Tuesday's appointments filled them. The other three rest on the Ordinance alone.

Article 124(i) leaves the number of judges to what Parliament may prescribe. An Article 123 Ordinance carries, for its life, the force of an Act. Independence of the judiciary is a basic feature of the Constitution. It is also about whether the court holds its seats free of obligation to the political branch. A court that owes three chairs to a six-week renewable Ordinance holds them at the executive's sufferance.

A test of principle

In 2015, a Constitution Bench decided *Supreme Court Advocates-on-Record Association vs Union of India*. It struck down the 99th Amendment and the National Judicial Appointments Commission. Parliament had passed it 367 to nil in the Lok Sabha, with the States ratifying. The commission was to have six members: the Chief Justice, the two senior-most judges after him, the Union Law Minister, and two eminent persons. The eminent persons were to be chosen by a panel of the Prime Minister, the Chief Justice, and the Leader of the Opposition. That composition was meant to keep the choice neutral. Yet the Act provided that any two members could veto a name. The court feared that the Law Minister and even one eminent person could thus block a candidate the judges favoured. It held that this destroyed the judiciary's primacy in its own appointments.

Yet the Supreme Court Collegium has accepted an Ordinance that seats three of its own, despite the uncertainty over its fate. Under Article 123, the President may withdraw an Ordinance at any time. Both Houses may disapprove it by resolution. Otherwise, it ceases to operate six weeks after Parliament reassembles.

The court itself taught the country to distrust the Ordinance. In *D.C. Wadhwa vs State of Bihar* (1986), it called governance by repromulgated ordinance a fraud on the Constitution. In *Krishna Kumar Singh vs State of Bihar* (2017), a seven-judge Bench ruled against using ordinance-making power as a parallel source of legislation.

If the Bill replaces the Ordinance, the



GETTY IMAGES



CJI Surya Kant administers the oath of office to Justice V. Mohana as a judge of the Supreme Court, in New Delhi on June 2. She is only the second woman to be elevated directly from the Bar to the court. PTI

anomaly closes. If not, the apex court's strength reverts to 34, and the executive cannot bridge the gap by repromulgation, the fraud Wadhwa condemned. Whether a judge appointed to an Ordinance-created post can be removed once that post lapses is untested. Their judgments hold under the de facto doctrine, affirmed in *Gokaraju Rangaraju vs State of Andhra Pradesh* (1981). The subtler harm is to appearance: in any matter touching the Union, the government whose majority must regularise their seats may appear before them. A judge whose tenure lies, even loosely, in one party's gift cannot wear the detachment the office demands.

The calculated risk

The court sits at 37; the 38th and last sanctioned post is empty, the calendar suggests why. Justice Pankaj Mithal retires on June 16 and Justice J.K. Maheshwari on June 28. Their retirements reopen two lawful seats, into which two of the three Ordinance judges move. A judge in the 38th post would be the junior-most. Its occupant would reach a lawful seat only at Justice Satish Chandra Sharma's retirement on November 29, months after the Ordinance expires. Leaving it empty spares the court a judge stranded that long.

That leaves Justice V. Mohana, alone of the five from the bar and so junior-most,

The five are fit for office: four sat as Chief Justices of High Courts, the fifth came from the bar

on an Ordinance post. She can reach a lawful seat only when Justice Sanjay Karol retires on August 22. Here, the Collegium seems to have taken a calculated risk. Justice Karol's retirement all but coincides with the Ordinance's likely lapse, six weeks into the monsoon session. The replacing law should thus arrive first, and even a short delay is caught by his vacancy, which absorbs her. Her position turns precarious only if the Ordinance is rejected or lapses before August 22. Then the strength reverts to 34, the court still sits at 35, and she holds a post that the law no longer recognises. That a judge of the highest court should depend on which reading prevails, and on when Parliament meets, is the disquiet.

Larger question

The wager will likely be won; the government has the numbers, and the Opposition will not unsettle freshly sworn judges. But that is not the point. The court has staked its independence and its judges' security of tenure on the goodwill of the executive and Parliament.

The U.S. Senate's warning of 1937 was against a court bound by obligation to the appointing power. The graver danger is a court that no longer notices the obligation. Independence of the judiciary is not only the right to say no to the executive. It is the instinct to want to. (V. Venkatesan is Contributing Editor at *Supreme Court Observer*. Views expressed are personal)

THE GIST

Five judges were sworn in to the Supreme Court after the sanctioned strength was raised from 34 to 38 through a Presidential Ordinance; while two appointments filled existing vacancies, three were made to newly created posts.

The Supreme Court has previously held in cases such as *D.C. Wadhwa vs State of Bihar* and *Krishna Kumar Singh vs State of Bihar* that ordinance-making power cannot become a parallel source of legislation and that repeated promulgation of ordinances is unconstitutional.

If Parliament does not replace the Ordinance with a law, the court's sanctioned strength would revert to 34, raising unresolved questions about the status of judges appointed to Ordinance-created posts and the legal implications of such appointments.

